

Films of 2025



Rules: 1) Almost always be (primarily) English language, 2) Must be a non-documentary feature. Sorry, otherwise this list gets another 20+ films added and I do not have that much time. 3) US Theatrical(-ish) release in 2025 (some of these films might have IMDb years for earlier due to film festival releases, or for example a 2024 Australian release before a 2025 US release). This year US theatrical-ish release has been pushed to its limits; some films with early 2025 releases – but a 2024 film festival showing – that were 2024 award eligible, are counted as 2024 and therefore are not included in this list. With the rise of (direct-to-) streaming, multiple awards have a TV-or-Streaming Movie Category. When applicable these films are included as well.

Within a tier, I believe the films are roughly the same quality. Between tiers, I believe there is enough distinction to say a film is better than those in the lower tier. Although, that distinction is blurrier for films at the bottom of a tier and the films at the top of the previous tier.

Selection Criteria: 1) Oscar Nominated, 2) Golden Globe Nominated, 3) Independent Spirit Awards, 4) BAFTA, 5) GLAAD Awards, 6) Black Reel Awards (replacing NAACP Image), 7) AACTA Awards (Australian Oscars) 8) Sundance, 9) Guild Awards: SAG, DGA, PGA, ACE, and ASC, 10) AFI Top 10, 11) National Board of Review, 12) Critics' Choice Awards, 13) British Independent Film Awards (BIFA), 14) Annie Awards, 15) My own idiosyncratic preferences, 16) Some heterogeneous-minimum Rotten Tomatoes score regardless if nominated. Note: These are not necessarily the ranking of a criterion's importance.

[A selection criterion is in brackets to give an idea of why the film was on my list; award nominations are given preference, but also my own idiosyncratic reasons for watching, when applicable. Films were on the list before awards seasons, but the nominations/awards reflect that these did end up being good films.]

Streaming service is up-to-date as of **6/7/26**; afterwards who knows. So watch them now. I only included without-ads services. I did not include 'free' streaming with a cable add-on (Starz, Showtime, etc). Many of these can be rented on streaming services, but the ability to rent was not included.

Tier 15: Atrocious is Too Kind a Word

212. **Peter Pan's Neverland Nightmare:** Why do I keep watching these Twisted Childhood Universe copyrightsplotation films? Even at ninety minutes it feels long. One wonders if they saw *The Black Phone* and decided that it should be remade, but awful. Outside of the opening kill, there isn't much interesting from a horror aspect (even a Marco Polo sequence can't illicit any frights). The film is a mess, though it apparently connects to *Blood and Honey 2* in a way I missed; because neither film is that good. Which is sad, because if the film had even a functional budget, and set in Neverland (instead of 'going to Neverland' meaning Peter has killed the child), with some actual character development for Pan, it could have been a solid use of the public domain. [Poorly-reviewed Horror]

Tier 14: Avoid

211. **Him:** The main thing saving the film from an even lower tier, is that some of the stylistic choices from co-writer-director Justin Tipping absolutely work. Except that the script is a constant letdown (and one wonders if at times he's ever followed the NFL; the young QB causes a controversy by skipping the combine; he also played four years in college but is also predicted as the next great. Oh and the player he might replace just won the 'Super Bowl'; all of these holes leave the viewer instantly disinterested). The script continues to bring up far too many plot points regarding dedication to sports and fame, such that none of them end up coming together. Likewise the horror elements, even early on, are not creepy enough to keep the viewer interested (often they are too outlandish, but the film is not trying to be campy so they do not work). The ending attempts to bring together some of the elements, but the film is too far gone to care. [Black Reel – Outstanding Breakthrough Performance Nominee], *HBOMax*.
210. **The Travellers:** This is a bad Hallmark movie, not an AACTA Best Film Nominee. One imagines it got the nominations because it is directed by Bruce Beresford (*Driving Miss Daisy* and *Ladies in Black*). But there is no character development, the film hops around Hallmark plot points: dying mom, needing to put dad in a home (and selling) the childhood home, hooking up with past exes, hateful locals, etc. The dialogue is often awful, and most of the actors give pathetic performances. The film is a massive miss. Thankfully it is only 95 minutes. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
209. **Oh. What. Fun.:** A Christmas film that doesn't know what it wants to be. It isn't a serious drama, despite wanting to be regarding the role of mom's. It isn't a comedy as the jokes aren't there. It isn't a parody of previous Christmas films, as parodies are funny. It isn't an homage to previous Christmas films as it explicitly wants to subvert them by focusing on the overworked mom. The assembled cast is great and yet they are given nothing to work with except for Dominic Sessa (*The Holdovers*) and Havana Rose Liu (*Bottoms*). The film is a gigantic mess that should be avoided. [GLAAD – Best Streaming Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
208. **Swiped:** A useless biopic about the founder of Bumble. Even ignoring that the film is far too kind to the founder (it ignores that she wasn't exactly self-made, or that Bumble's stock has tanked, or her role, or any role of apps, in the decline in actual dating), the film is more interested in being a lazy #MeToo. Lily James exists as the lead, but doesn't bring much to the character (in part because the script is not interested in developing any characters). The film goes thru the motions of simplistic female empowerment, and often feels like a plea to help boost Bumble's cratering stock. [WGA – Best TV Movie Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.
207. **The Old Guard 2:** How did it take five years to follow up an enjoyable action film with this pile of trash? It should be noted that the director did not return. The film's plot takes nearly the entire film to actually get going. The opening sequence is not exciting. The fight choreography is often pathetic. Some of the most basic shots manage to have lens flare. It contains lots of 'Netflix-dialogue'

in that the plot points are straight-up said by characters, multiple times. The film then ends with setting up a third installment, but after this massive dud, its hard to be interested in it. [GLAAD – Outstanding Streaming Nominee], *Netflix*.

206. **Snow White:** What a CGI mess. From the ‘sets’ to the ‘backgrounds’ (even the animals aren’t great). The film is essentially ruined from the start with how cheap it looks (and the lazy exposition). Rachel Zegler (*West Side Story*) is good and is so charming she nearly saves the movie. Yet just when you think she will: a bad song is sung, Gal Gadot does an accent no one has ever heard, and then the biggest offense is the CGI dwarfs. The dwarfs are awful and once they show up, the movie is ruined for good (worst off, the movie shoe-horned in an actual little person in a supporting role!). The movie does not work. [*Disney Live-action*], *Disney+*.
205. **The Electric State:** The film is not as bad as its Rotten Tomatoes score may indicate (part of the bad reviews are super punishing the fact the film cost over 300 million dollars and assembled an all-star cast only produce nothing of value; that the budget could have finance dozens of other films). The film is completely forgettable, which lazy dialogue often functioning as repeating exposition. There is essentially no character development. The jokes are not fun. Stanley Tucci phoned in his performance. Nothing the film wants to say about technology works (partially because for themes to land there need to be character development). The action sequences contain zero action. The entire film is a nothing burger. [Razzies – Worst Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.
204. **Captain America: Brave New World:** The MCU has really fallen off a cliff. The earlier movies were at least tolerable, now they are often a slog. The VFX in the film look extremely cheap, which is baffling given a 180 million dollar budget. The fight choreography is pathetic, and yet the fights keep coming. Simply trimming down the fight scenes could have gotten the film down about ten–fifteen minutes making it a bit more tolerable. And I am not even punishing the film for its lazy appeal-to-everyone political takes, which also resulted in a fair bit of criticism. Danny Ramirez (*Top Gun: Maverick*) is enjoyable while neither Anthony Mackie or Harrison Ford phone in their performances, which given the quality of the film they probably should have. [Black Reel – Outstanding Production Design Nominee], *Disney+*.
203. **Freaky Tales:** Co-written and co-directed by Anna Boden and Ryan Fleck (*Mississippi Grind*), the film is a love letter to the East Bay; particularly the late-80s East Bay. Yet it frequently feels as if they wanted to make a love letter, but never figured out how. The film is more of an anthology in four parts. Technically there is some slight overlap but it is minor. There is a sci-fi aspect but it doesn’t not exactly work. Pedro Pascal is good, but Ben Mendelsohn (*Starred Up*) is the best. Few of the jokes land and stylistic choices are certainly choices. The best part of the film is a surprise appearance by [redacted]. [Black Reel – Outstanding Score Nominee], *HBOMax*.
202. **The Shrouds:** An absolute miss from David Cronenberg (*Stereo*), and not even because it lacks a lot of his signature body horror elements. The actors given the most bland performances of all-time and the dialogue is nothing special either. Then the film itself tries to cover too many themes: love and grief, cybersecurity, money in politics, Artificial Intelligence, among others. None of these end up landing. The ‘twists’ and ‘turns’ do not work. There was something about ruminating about death and the loss of loved ones, but nothing ends up working. [Cronenberg]
201. **Wolf Man:** I am sure Universal will continue trying to reboot its Monster Universe, but this installment was a miss. The goodwill generated by writer-director Leigh Whannell from smartly rebooting the universe with *The Invisible Man* is now gone. The themes are often muddled and lazy with their development; is it about the passing along of radicalization from father to son (which has been done many times before and much better)? Is it about the mother’s role (Julia Gardner tries to give her character depth, but the script did not). Also, for a horror there are not any scares (one of the body horror bits might land but those are few and far between). [Universal Monsters], *Amazon Prime*.

200. **After the Hunt:** Directed by Luca Guadagnino (*Challengers* and *Queer*) and he shares some responsibility for this flop. His direction is at times good (the diner scenes and excellently composed), while the musical choices are often bad (the ticking sound to start the film does not work and it comes back). Whereas the fault of the film is entirely from first-time screenwriter Nora Garrett. Given the first name, I assume Nora is a woman, and because of that the film made me question the value of the suffrage movement. That is how bad the script is. Set in Yale's philosophy department, Nora has never spoke to an academic in her life (first off why is someone Julia Roberts age on the tenure clock?, why doesn't Andrew Garfield instantly bring the plagiarism accusations to Roberts? I could go on). The film also wants to raise questions around sexual assault, youth culture, and about fifteen more topics it forces into the plot, but then never answer any of them. This doesn't even include the mind-numbing dialogue. It's also over two hours. There are some bright spots: some of the direction, the acting. But overall, it is a complete mess who's fault is solely the screenwriter's. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Drama Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
199. **Anaconda:** I wanted to enjoy the film, but the script is so bad it is impossible to enjoy. When both Paul Rudd and Jack Black are struggling to get laughs out of an audience you know there is a problem. And the film could have worked as a meta-satire of reboots (as it tries to be about it at times). Its not scary. Its not thrilling. Its not funny. And unlike the bad films in the next tier up, this has nothing to hold up as worthwhile. Perhaps in twenty years we can reboot this reboot and do it properly. [*Anaconda* Franchise], *Netflix*.

Tier 13: Bad, But Something Tolerable Does Exist

198. **Dora and the Search for Sol Dorado:** Make no mistake, this is purely a children's movie. Even as other nostalgia films, attempt to have some appeal towards adults, the only adult appeal in this is the frequent *Indiana Jones* references. The film does combine a lot of the stuff from the show. But its too cheesy, too manic-paced (at times), too geared towards children. By being purely for kids, it rarely gets actively awful, and so it can't rank in the lower tier, even though it very well could. [I Watched Dora as a Kid], *Paramount+*.
197. **Love Hurts:** The film is only 81 minutes, which is what 'elevates' into this tier. Yes it is often bad, but its over quickly. 81 minutes of awful is far easier to tolerate than two hours. The entire Valentine's Day theme is nonsensical and adds nothing to the film (also that Ariana DeBose (*West Side Story*) and Ke Huy Quan (*Everything Everywhere All At Once*) are in love with each other is stretch). The fight scenes are not very good (though they apparently try to capture the feeling of the various Kung Fu movies). Few of the jokes land. At least Marshawn Lynch (*Bottoms*) remains fun. [Had to See if the Bad Reviews Were Right], *Amazon Prime*.
196. **The Life List:** The film is rarely ever bad (except when it drags over two hours instead of being 100 minutes). Whereas a few films in their tier are probably worse, but you can have fun with bad. You can't have fun with stale. The script wants emotional moments and they never really occur (and it wants too many of them; loss of a parent, finding love, father relationships, being a teacher. It tried doing too much). Sofia Carson (*Carry-On*) can't carry the film, while Kyle Allen (*Rosaline*) is decent. But nothing ever works because it wants to repeat every trope we've seen a million times before hand. [WGA – Best Streaming Screenplay Nominee], *Netflix*.
195. **Fixed:** An adult-oriented animated film about a dog who is about to lose his balls. Except the film never does anything with that premise, and instead of developing characters, it relies on raunchy jokes; most of which do not land. Which is a bit sad as Idris Elba and Kathryn Hahn do a solid job voice acting in their supporting roles. But there are only so many times a joke can be repeated, and this film ends up repeating a lot of them. And in doing so, the gags which should land fail to elicit

lots of laughs because there is no plot. Unlike *Sausage Party* this film is a dud, despite some nice old-school two-dimensional animation. [Annie – Best Character Design Nominee], *Netflix*.

194. **Five Nights at Freddy's 2:** Perhaps I am being a little too kind to this sequel as once you know the underlying quality of the franchise it is a little easier to follow along the ride; again it isn't scary (and not even because of the PG-13 rating) nor thrilling. The actors phone in their performances; Wayne Knight took that paycheck. McKenna Grace is in the film for all of a few seconds and one wonders why she even bothered joining the cast. This film apparently incorporates more of the game-play from the source video games. But it made a boat-load of money and set up a third installment that I'll hate-watch. [Sequel], *Peacock*.
193. **Soul on Fire:** Every year, there is one film on The List that I watch and I have no idea why it was ever added. This is the entry for 2025. My guess is that it featured William H Macy as Jack Buck in a supporting role? As the film is a standard inspirational true story, with some faith-based elements (the film does keep these close to the chest until the final thirty minutes). However the dialogue is often laughable, and some of the line delivery is sad as well. The actress who plays the would-be wife, can not pull-off being a college student. Its not very good, and I don't even remember when I would have seen the trailer to add it to the list. [No Idea]
192. **Magic Beach:** This isn't a feature narrative feature film, but rather a loose collection of animated shorts (with each short directed by a different animator). The shorts vary in quality, but often have different animation styles which is nice to see. But by time the third one roles around at minute twenty, the viewer has checked out. Perhaps if I read the children's book the film is based on it would have landed more, but it becomes a chore as there is not real connective tissue (the titular beach is not enough). The dog-paint, battle robots, and pirates are probably the best sequences. [AACTA – Best Indie Film Nominee]
191. **Another Simple Favor:** While the first film was fun and thrilling, this one is neither. Blake Lively is still able to ham it up nicely and her chemistry with Anna Kendrick, almost makes the film passable. Yet the film seems more interested in showing off the Italian island of Capri. The suspense and twists from the first film are gone, and often replaced with forced laughs; the aunt (played by Allison Janney) and the FBI Agent being the two worst examples. The outfits are still great (and the good kid of outlandish). But instead of making another thriller, this leaned into camp and ended up being an unfunny miss. [Sequel], *Amazon Prime*.
190. **Regretting You:** The film assembles a great cast Allison Williams (*Get Out*), McKenna Grace (*Captain Marvel*), Dave Franco (*The Disaster Artist*), and Mason Thames (*The Black Phone*) along with a few others. Yet dear lord the source material from Colleen Hoover is pathetic; 'Find Your Passion' is pinned on the mother's dream board. Dave Franco plays the 'nerd' which just means they put glasses on him. The mother claims to have not left the couch in two days; perfect hair and make up. Allison Williams particularly phones in her performance, and even one line that made the final cut, she half breaks character laughing. At least it is bad in the trashy bad way, making it an enjoyable bad watch. [Cheesy Romance], *Paramount+*.
189. **Fear Street: Prom Queen:** Leigh Janiak no longer wrote and directed and the fun series took a massive hit. Co-writer and director Matt Palmer is not up to the task to both write a spooky and meaningful film, or create a visual identity for this film. Instead the film runs head-first into every high school cliché imaginable. Which is sad, as the assembled cast is once again solid: Suzanna Son (*Red Rocket*), Fina Strazza, and Ariana Greenblatt (*Barbie*) being the best of the young actresses (sadly the lead is not talent enough to keep up with any of them). Hopefully a good writer can redeem the series as Netflix appears willing to churn these out. [*Fear Street* franchise], *Netflix*.

188. **The SpongeBob Movie: Search for SquarePants:** At 90 minutes, the film is broken into thirds; an initial third which is a complete chore to slog thru and the viewer basically loses interest. The middle third, the film finally gets back to most of what makes the original series enjoyable and the laughs begin to start. Whereas the final third is then simply tolerable. The 3-dimensional animation doesn't quite work and there isn't enough for adults or fans of the first few seasons. [Annie's –Best Character Design Nominee], *Paramount+*.
187. **M3GAN 2.0:** The mild horror of the first film has been replaced with more action sequences, and lots of statements about Artificial Intelligence. The first half hour of bringing back the titular robot work, but the final third eventually goes completely off the rails with needless twists. The villains border on cartoonish. The self-aware jokes do not exactly land. Though Allison Williams (*Regretting You*) does seem to embrace the plot's silliness, whereas everything involving Timm Sharp's character is a chore. [Sequel], *Netflix*.
186. **Opus:** The film isn't *bad*, but in five minutes the viewer knows exactly where the film will end up. There is no true suspense. There is no real mystery. The themes are then spelled out directly, multiple times. Also, for a film about a world famous singer, there should have been more and better songs. It gets hard to believe this man has a cult (of personality) around him when they only play a single song that isn't even a bop. Its too predictable and lazy with its themes to be worthwhile. Ayo Edebiri gives it her best effort, despite a bunch of lazy performances around her; John Malkovich has fun but not enough to carry the leading role. [Ayo Edebiri], *HBOMax*.
185. **Death of a Unicorn:** A film where the cheap VFX hurt, but the rest of the film isn't good enough to justify better effects. The best jokes were all included in the trailer, and almost the entirety of them were delivered by Will Poulter (*Midsommar*), who really has perfected the cocky-but-alooof asshole (Anthony Carrigan (*Barry*) also tries to provide some comedy but his lines are much worse he can't save them). The film itself is too long and needed to be a tight 90 minutes. The 'action' scenes are neither tense or scary (or even comical; the film never figures out it's goal). It ends up being a lazy social satire and doesn't get much out of its cast. [Great Cast], *HBOMax*.
184. **Love Me:** A great idea for a *short* film. Even at 95 minutes it has a few lulls. Yet the premise is amazing; a bouy and a satellite fall in love and 'become' human after the apocalypse. It has a strong feeling of *Wall-E* and *2001*. It is helped that the two leads are played/voiced by Kristen Stewart and Steven Yeun; both are able to pull the film through the lulls. The film has a fair bit to say about what it means to be human, evolution, (artificial) intelligence, and love. Yet because the premise is so simple, it becomes difficult to get 90 minutes of quality content. [Sundance – Grand Jury Prize Nominee], *Hulu*.
183. **Eden:** Ron Howard (*Hillbilly Elegy*) assembled an all-star cast (Jude Law, Vanessa Kirby, Ana de Armas, Sydney Sweeney, and Daniel Brühl) only to let them down with a weak script. Too many of the actors attempt a German accent, and they all fail at it (sans Bruil who is actually German). de Armas' cartoon villain drives the plot forward, but films should never rely on cartoon villains to progress the plot because then there are no real stakes all while the viewer loses interest. Sydney Sweeney tries her best to save the final thirty minutes, but by then the film is too far gone. The script also does a poor job of pacing the events and building tension; there are a few time jumps (with the seasons) and the viewer gets told things have changed. Rather than slowly ramp up tension the script simply skips ahead to the breaking points. [Ron Howard], *Netflix*.
182. **The Surfer:** Directed by Lorcan Finnegan (*Vivarium*), and he is another in a line of a director I don't care for as both films had decent reviews, but I did not care for. His direction is too stylized and the writing is more interested in keeping the plot opaque and bizarre instead of developing his characters (perhaps some of the 'love' is that people can impart whatever theory they want to explain the plot; they get to feel smart). And the overly-warm Australian beach/parking lot do often look

nice, but at times it goes too far into being stylized (there is an argument that maybe if one watched more 70s surfer films this one would improve? but I have yet to see any of them). Nic Cage goes full, as to be expected and does his best to make the film worthwhile, despite all of the directorial and writing choices. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee], *Hulu*.

181. **A Big Bold Beautiful Journey:** What a miss from Kogonada (*Columbus* and *After Yang*). The first thirty minutes of the film are promising with his usual flair for camerawork and set design (and one even starts wondering how the reviews were so negative). The premise is a bit of fantasy, but easy to go along with; two lonely single people go on a road trip together (yet, the GPS calls it a Big Bold Beautiful Journey) stopping at doors which take them to relive moments from their past. The first few doors are nice, but each door only takes a few minutes, with well over an hour left of film. This becomes annoyingly repetitive; although the characters are being developed, it is being done in the lazy and obvious way, to where any quirkiness of the film dissipates and all that remains is a slog of doors to still be opened resulting in zero emotional payoff and in-your-face philosophical lessons. [Kogonada], *Netflix*.
180. **Anemone:** The definition of style over substance. The directorial debut of Ronan Day-Lewis features a lot of flashy camerawork and lighting, but is nearly devoid of any real character development or drama. The film starts off with minimal dialogue (which the viewer slowly realizes was as smart choice due to how poor the eventual dialogue becomes). There are only two actual scenes of legitimate character development (beyond wandering in the woods and stares) and each turns into a lengthy monologue delivered by Daniel Day-Lewis; he is good as to be expected but even he can't carry the film. After an hour one thinks the film is about the wrap up, only to discover there is still an hour to go. Then a forest spirit shows up followed by comically large hail storm. The film is a miss and a slog, and only worth watching if you really want to see another Daniel Day-Lewis performance. [British Independent Film – Best Sound Nominee], *Netflix*.

Tier 12: If A Little Better They'd be Fun and Failed Prestige Films

179. **Honey, Don't!:** Margaret Qualley, Aubrey Plaza, and Chris Evans are all so electric they can make the movie tolerable. With the Coen Brothers working separately, this is Ethan Coen's second solo film (*Drive-Away Dolls*) and its becoming clear he was the weaker brother; though bringing the mild absurdity which made their best films elite. As this film has multiple absurd ideas, and some crazy jokes, but not enough jokes to work as a comedy. And it certainly doesn't work as a noir film. There are a few twists that are nonsensical and add little to the film as none of the plots work on their own nor do they come together in a fulfilling manner. If you like one of the leads, then you can get some brief enjoyment out of the film, otherwise Ethan Coen continues to offer very little on his own. [Ethan Coen], *Netflix*.
178. **Queens of the Dead:** The film assembles a whos-who of recent LGBT cinema: Katy O'Brian (*Love Lies Bleeding*), Jaquel Spivey (*Mean Girls*), Jack Haven (*I Saw the TV Glow*), Tomas Matos (*Fire Island*), and Eve Lindley (*National Anthem*). Yet the film ends up being far more interested in forced campiness than horror or genuine comedy. As zombies attacking a drag club is ripe for horror comedy. Yet, neither the horror nor the comedy come thru (there are a lot of failed horror-comedies this year). By trying to force the laughs, none of the laughs end up working and viewer spends the film waiting for it to be over; as even sequences that could be funny are directly poorly which reflects on first-time director Tina Romero. [Well-reviewed Horror]
177. **The Twits:** What saves this film (at least for rated this lowly) is the animation is stylized and unique. As the film itself never settles on a tone: social satire, musical, and low-brow comedy are all thrown together in a way that never gels; especially the songs/musical numbers. The commentary on current politics feels forced. Oh, also the film is told as a bedtime story from a mother firefly. It

doesn't work. But in an era of characters and backgrounds becoming rather similar the uniqueness of the animation makes it nearly tolerable. [Annie – Best Character Design Nominee], *Netflix*.

176. **Atropia:** An Iraq War satire, that loses its way. The film often is able to nail the feeling of the early-to-mid 00s, which helps. Except the jokes eventually stop landing and despite being nearly 20 years removed, the film finds little new to say about our time in Iraq and the Bush-era as a whole. When the film shifts gears to a love story between Alia Shawkat and Callum Turner it falls apart as the actors have little chemistry and the script does not give them much of a reason to be together beyond needing to advance the plot. It often ends up feeling like a bad episode of *Arrested Development*. The rest of the cast is secretly stacked, but there is little room for them to do much of value. [Sundance – Grand Jury Prize]
175. **Happy Gilmore 2:** I'm not sure a sequel was needed, nor that this has a great idea for one; Happy has lost his money and become an alcoholic but a still supportive father. The film features far too many callbacks to the original (complete with clips spliced in to remind the audience). Bringing back a character or two would have been nice, but nearly every living character returns. The golfer cameos are a little grating (some are good, but they take up too much time; there is no reason for the film to be two hours). Likewise in the inclusion of Brooks Koepka and Bryson DeChambeau is at odds with the plot of the film: a new start-up golf league wants to compete with The Tour. Brooksy and Bryson are literally LIV golfers! They are the bad guys! Its hard to make a social commentary land when they are included. And of course Sandler cast half his family in roles. [Sequel], *Netflix*.
174. **The Wrong Paris:** I watched this after Indiana Football won the National Championship, it took a lot not to over rank this and move it up a tier. As it is a cheesy rom-com and boy does that hit hard after winning it all. Yes, it fairly standard with the only real change being making fun of dating reality tv shows (I don't watch them, but I think the film did a decent job of explaining the tropes?). Miranda Cosgrove (*iCarly*) and Pierson Fodé (*Jessie*) are both attractive and get along well. The dresses are rather nice, but I get the impression they are not custom made. Enjoy the good time and hot people falling in love. [Cheesey Rom-com], *Netflix*.
173. **Eleanor the Great:** The directorial debut of Scarlett Johansson, and either she chose a poor screenplay or was out of her depth. As the film is about a woman who (accidentally?) shares the Holocaust survival story of her recently-deceased best friend. The script can't keep the tonal shifts together (the screenwriting debut of Tory Kamen) and Johansson can't keep them in order either (its hard to know who to blame; but combining two first-timers on such a difficult premise was going to result in failure). Some people might be swayed by the feel-good endings (there are at least two of them). June Squibb (*Thelma*) is good and provides some of the laughs and keeps the plot going for the most part. [June Squibb], *Netflix*.
172. **Keeper:** A bit of a dud by director Osgood Perkins (though he was not the screenwriter and that could explain the decrease in quality). Actually that is probably the reason, and most of the issues are a result of a weak script (its production was a way around Hollywood Labor disputes by using a Canadian cast and crew to keep the crew from *The Monkey* employed). So can I even fault him for this rushed dud? As the film has Perkins slow moving camera and detailed framing. But essentially zero scares and a plot that although it comes together at the end doesn't make much logical sense. Though Tatiana Maslany is decent in the leading role. [Osgood Perkins]
171. **One of Them Days:** I hate this genre; the 'frantic'-day-from-hell-where-nothing-goes-right. I think because the only way for these to 'work' is that you need to willingly be friends who constantly mess things up because of their own stupidity. Also, one needs to ignore how difficult it is to evict tenants in Los Angeles for the plot to make any sense; the plot is driven by that they need to get *that month's rent* to the landlord on the *first of the month* or else get instantly evicted. Keke Palmer (*Nope*) is decent, but not good enough to carry a film that is also lacking in laughs (or needs to to

go absurd lengths for them; getting shoes off a power line being the works offender). [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *Netflix*.

170. **Bring Them Down:** A farming drama about toxic masculinity that can never deliver on its themes, as too much of the plot was nonsensical character choices (admittedly it was mainly just one choice that then ruined the entire film for me). Even though the film did set up one character having caused a fatal car crash previously, that still should not explain how you actively rescue a rival farm who has rustled your livestock. Rusting is a mortal sin of farming and should trump any and all character development. The film also then replays the first forty minutes from another character's point of view, so that the film gets tedious. Only a few minutes of the change is needed to reveal what has been going on, but it continues and causes the film to drag. Neither Christopher Abbott (*Poor Things*) and Barry Keoghan (*The Banshees of Inisherin*) are both decent but not able to carry the film. [British Independent Film – Best Debut Director]
169. **Steve:** A film that means wells, but absolutely can not pull off its premise. The direction and stylistic choices almost never work. The documentary crew means the first half bounces between camera shows and purposely dated documentary shots (to resemble the mid-90s). The non-documentary shots are often hand-held and become distracting. The dialogue is often inaudible, and then the film switches to blasting music. There is a nice-looking drone shot, but it adds nothing to the film and actually actively detracts from the film. The film wants to focus on both the director of the reform school, and the students, and by splitting the time between them, it serves none of the characters well. The film also assumes that these children should have a chance of redemption; that the audience needs to fully buy in to the directors view of the world; it never once considers that some might be too dangerous. It is an all around miss. [BATFA – Outstanding British Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
168. **Beast of War:** A World War II shark attack film should be more enjoyable. Though, perhaps if one fully turned their brain off it would be enjoyable. As the Australian film really hammers home the Indigenous vs White plot line, and what strength/courage/leadership really look like (hint: the racist white guy has no good qualities). Because of the black and white characters the film can never go anywhere. The action tries to build and the film does a decent job of trying to make a small tank look like the pacific ocean; if anything the visual success on a small budget is the best part of the film. [AACTA – Best Cinematography Nominee]
167. **Elio:** Pixar has lost its way in the script/plot department though it is still nearly unbeatable when it comes to animation quality. Some of the scenes on the beach with the sand and waves were showing off. But of course things should look that good on a budget of 200 million; am I rewarding animation quality or dollars spent at this point? (I think I said the same exact thing about *Lightyear*.) As while most Pixar films have had loveable losers, the recent ones have started featuring straight-up losers (*Onward*, *Turning Red*, and *Inside Out 2*). The titular Elio is their worst offender yet, and a character who deserves to be bullied. Finding yourself is a good moral, but there is also a moral of fitting in (*The Lion King*) that is completely lacking from this film. Brad Garrett (*Everybody Loves Raymond*) is good as the villain. Otherwise, there isn't much to this film. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Disney+*.
166. **Spinal Tap II: The End Continues:** Another cash-grab sequel in this tier. Thankfully the callbacks are dialed down a little compared to *Happy Gilmore 2*. But here, the best parts of the film are not the original cast, but cameos from Paul McCartney and Elton John. Seeing those two legends preform ends up being better than most of the film. And much like *Happy Gilmore 2*, the cameos are lengthy and semi-forced (especially in trying to recruit a new drummer). There are some funny parts, and the dry humor still remains, however much like the first, I am not much of a fan. [Sequel, RIP Rob Reiner], *HBOMax*.

165. **A Minecraft Movie:** The assembled cast has fun: Jack Black, Jason Momoa, Emma Myers, and Danielle Brooks (Jennifer Coolidge as has fun, but her character isn't needed). The script lets them go off (especially with every single song; there is an argument we could have given Jack Black another Best Original Song nominee), and I assume it also has lots of Minecraft Easter eggs/fan service that went over my head. Except, at every turn, the film chose to appeal to children. It would start to develop some deeper connection, but it would then spell the themes out and essentially preach to kids to find their own way. The film is still fun, and rarely a chore, but had it tried to focus a little bit more on adults the film would have succeeded more. [Annie – Best Character Animation in Live Action Nominee], *HBOMax*.
164. **Harvest:** The film is labeled as a folk-horror, but there is nothing scary about it. Perhaps if I didn't know its 'genre' it might have been able to move up a little bit (but not much). The cinematography by Sean Price Williams (*The Sweet East*) is often good, but the film purposely tries to give the edges of the frame a ragged look which distract. But the main reason the film doesn't work is it is a lazy Marxist film about collective ownership. The takeaway of the film shouldn't be that the villagers are exploited, but that the private land ownership allowed for the start of economic growth and the rise in living standards. But that wouldn't fly in left-wing film-making circles (and I think I was too generous with the ranking because the politics of the film grated me so). [British Independent Film – Best Production Design Nominee]
163. **In Your Dreams:** In some ways, this ranking is a little too harsh. The animation is rather good (as one would expect when sand is featured so heavily). The character development is decent. Yet, the plot is something we've seen a million times: an older daughter wishing her parents won't split up and not liking having a younger sibling (why they share a room, but said room fits at least two double beds is a plot hole). Its that familiarity; a film that would have been groundbreaking fifteen years ago, feels routine. The plot doesn't offer enough new material for the adults watching. [Critics Choice – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
162. **The Roses:** A waste of the talent of everyone involved. The leads of Benedict Cumberbatch and Olivia Coleman do not have much chemistry. Director Jay Roach (*Austin Powers* and *Trumbo*) can't get the tone quite right. Writer Tony McNamara (*The Favourite*, *Cruella*, *The Great*) can't deliver enough jokes or properly ramp up the zaniness; as the final third goes off the rails completely but there was never enough build up to it (one assumes more effort was made in modernizing the adaptation from the 1981 source material than writing a solid script). At least there are a few scenes with Andy Samberg and Kate McKinnon who are both excellent and are able to inject the film with some life each time they are on screen. The movie is rarely bad, but after the first twenty-five-ish minutes the film starts to simply exist; doing nothing with the talent involved. [Decently-reviewed Comedy], *Hulu*.
161. **Summer of 69:** A generic coming-of-age sexually film. The film hits the various sex positive ideas in fashion (the gag about instructing a blindfolded driver was good, but went on too long). It is co-written and directed by Jillian Bell (*Britney Runs a Marathon*) in her directorial debut, and there are some laughs, just not enough. Chloe Fineman is decent, but not great; same with Sam Morelos (*Regretting You*). Charlie Day shows up and hams it up too much that the character's jokes do not land. And by time Natalie Morales (*If You Were the Last*) shows up it is too late. The general ideas work, but the script needed to be funnier and more logical, before leaning into the inevitable reconciliations. [Critics Choice – Best TV Movie Nominee], *Hulu*.
160. **On Swift Horses:** Another example of an LGBT film that is fifteen years too late. As it inverts the premise of the wife and brother potentially having an affair, and instead reveals each character is gay. Yet, no amount of star power (Daisy Edgar Jones (*Twisters*) and Jacob Elordi (*Priscilla*)) can overcome a basic script. Although these characters discover their sexuality (Elordi's always knew it),

there isn't much actual discovery. The sets and costumes are decent, but not special enough to aid in overcoming the script's shortcomings. Likewise the same applies to the cinematography. It is a film where all of the pieces should be there for something good, and instead the end product is generic. [GLAAD – Outstanding Wide Release Nominee], *Netflix*.

159. **Kangaroo:** A family-friendly heart-warming movie about redemption (even if the redemption part of the story was not true in real life). Plus the baby kangaroos are cute. Actually, the baby kangaroos do a lot of the heavy lifting here (the CGI jacked kangaroo is inspired by the meme kangaroo; which is what the movie is based on). The plot is standard, the supporting characters are standard. Everything is pretty much standard. But again, the kangaroos are cute and rarely is the film bad. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
158. **Love, Brooklyn:** A romance drama (and love letter to the borough) gets bogged down by lengthy dialogue, iffy lighting, and people living in apartments they have no business affording (this isn't a criticism I usually have, but when the film wants to be more serious, it should get these details right). As the film ends up in that awkward place of never being bad with poor dialogue and bad acting (Roy Wood Jr (*The Daily Show*) is enjoyable in a supporting role), but that it lacks anything worth holding onto. The premise is not interesting enough nor is it romantic enough to keep the viewers attention. As the film drifts on it take a while to conclude because the various scenes always end up needed five minutes of bland dialogue. [Black Reel – Outstanding Independent Film Nominee]
157. **Springsteen: Deliver Me From Nowhere:** A beyond standard biopic that wastes time with Springsteen's relationship with his father, and well as a brief relationship he had at the time. Whereas the heart of the film is the creation of the *Nebraska* album and the fight to get it released. If anything, Jeremy Strong's character should have been the main character as then the film would have avoided nearly all of the musician biopic tropes. Jeremy Allen White seems to be playing his character from *The Bear* (a depressed perfectionist) which does fit Bruce at the time, its hard to say he's bringing much new to the character, especially as most of the songs are the original Bruce recordings. The script itself is often lazy, as ideas are repeated multiple times to ensure the audience can follow along. Thankfully the film looks decent and Bruce is great. [Golden Globes – Best Actor in a Drama Nominee], *Hulu*.
156. **Anniversary:** A 'political' thriller about how one family deals with the rise of a fascist government. Yet the film is never interested in how exactly said government comes to power, and then consolidates power. All of that is glossed over with time jumps a year or two into the future. It ends up not working at all as a script. However, an absolutely stacked cast makes up for a lot of the flaws: Diane Lane, Kyle Chandler, Zoey Deutch, McKenna Grace, Daryl McCormack, Madeline Brewer with Dylan O'Brien and Phoebe Dynevor delivering the best two performances. The costume design is also rather nice. Yet sadly a script and plot which leaves too much unexplored and unexplained results in an uneven film. [Great Cast], *Hulu*.
155. **Ella MaCay:** The film is straight out of the 90s, and in a bad way. The morals, ethics, and issues are just dated. The film wants to hit on just about every social issue imaginable, and crafts enough side characters to ensure that can happen; Ayo Edebiri's character is probably the worst offender. All of these characters mean that the film can't get home its main points with any crafting and instead results to being ham-fisted. Which is sad as Emma Mackay does try to keep the film afloat (and those jackets!). The film also refuses to name the state, despite making heavy use of the Rhode Island capitol building. There are moments where the dialogue dips into old-school sitcoms that director James L Brooks created, but those moments are fleeting (or Jamie Lee Curtis overdoes it and ruins it). [James L Brooks], *Hulu*.

Tier 11: Fun Films and Middling Dramas

154. **Bone Lake:** The film never figured out if it wanted to be a horror or an erotic thriller. As a result neither element is done well (at times it feels like a far inferior *The Rental*). And it is sad, as the general premise of two couples forced to share a vacation rental absolutely works. But the film isn't scary enough to be a horror, nor is it sexy enough to be an erotic thriller (walking into a room of sex toys isn't sexy; using them is!). Marco Pigossi who was a find in *High Tide*, ends up being a dud in this film (dare I say as a gay man he doesn't convincingly play a straight man?). The rest of the cast is also a bunch of meh performances who can't elevate mediocre dialogue. An idea was here, but none of the execution was. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Netflix*.
153. **Dog Man:** Ninety minutes of stupid fun. Lots of gags in the background, and some are probably missed. The animation quality is a tad cheap, but it makes up for with enough heart and lots of comedy. The voice cast is great, especially Lil Rel Howery, though Pete Davidson and Ricky Gervais are rather good as well. The morals and character development can be seen a mile away, but given how the film knows itself, they end up working. What should result in a facepalm for stupidity ends up with a cute little aww. As even if the film is for children, there is enough for adults to enjoy. [Annie – Best Voice Acting Nominee], *Netflix*.
152. **With or Without You:** The film itself is rather standard blending of a few genres and each hit the genre tropes on the beats; an alcoholic mother, an abusive ex-boyfriend, a refugee who's visa is about to expire, etc. There are far too many forced plot points and drama. Yet Melina Vidler and Albert Mwangi's chemistry makes the film work. They can overcome each of the standard plot points (which all will happen) to make the film decent. [AACTA – Best Indie Film Nominee]
151. **Christy:** A generic biopic that doesn't give Sydney Sweeney much room to flex, and is likewise more interested in how much hair and make-up could be applied to Ben Foster. Co-written and directed by David Michôd (*The Rover* and *War Machine*), it continues his up-and-down filmography. The handling of sexual orientation is dated and although it should be an important plot point it becomes a chore. The film is also essentially split into two; her boxing career, and then her personal life. Although the personal life portion should connect, nothing was set up properly during the lead up to her fights. The real-life Christy has a life worth filming, but it needed more nuance and character development to overcome its overly long runtime. [Sydney Sweeney], *HBOMax*.
150. **Clown in a Cornfield:** The underlying premise is great, but the film had no clue how to properly execute the idea (though it did know how to execute the various teens). The film wants to be a slasher with social commentary about generation gaps and declining middle-America. Yet all of those themes become ham-fisted and drilled into the audience with speeches. The whole stick-shift is the worst offender. It also doesn't help that Aaron Abrams plays a dollar-store Andrew Garfield character. Thankfully, Katie Douglas is decent as The Final Girl. Although the film never gets bad, one wishes the ideas and themes came together in a more meaningful way. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release Nominee], *Hulu*.
149. **Oh, Hi:** A modern relationship-comedy that is held together by the strength of Molly Gordon (*Theater Camp*). She is hilarious and makes the film work despite needing more on the drama side (like too many comedies these days it wants to have some seriousness how the current state of dating, but those themes aren't developed enough and then detract from the comedy (and makes one wish the film was funnier; not because the jokes don't land but because the film lets off the gas). The 90-minute runtime helps move things along, despite the film not taking full advantage of its ideas. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *Netflix*.
148. **Sarah's Oil:** It takes a minute or two, but you quickly realize that this is a children's film. That isn't exactly a bad thing, but any true drama and character development will be thrown out the window for something that Disney could churn out. The villains are cartoon villains. Good conquers evil. People learn their lessons and improve and become less racist. It is almost if Disney made *Killers of*

the Flower Moon. The sets and costumes are nice. The actors do a decent job. But again, everything is aimed at children and the film can then only rank so high. [Black Reel – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee]

147. **Brides:** A difficult film to accurately rank, as it never quite entertains the fact that leaving England to join ISIS is a bad decision and those doing so are awful people (the ending audio is not enough). It never leans into they-are-teens-and-don't-know-better territory either. Instead it tries to ignore that and focus on the friendship via a non-linear plot (the flashbacks do save the film, as if it was presented in a straight-forward manner the film would have been intolerable). The film also does not realize the one mother is the most interesting character and does not fully develop her as a supporting character. Yet the friendship is well done and builds to the (stupid) conclusion. If the friendship gets you, it could go a tier higher, if the ISIS gets you, it could be two tiers lower. [British Independent Film – Best Breakthrough Performance Nominee]
146. **The Monkey:** Osgood Perkins (*Longlegs*) continues to churn out horror movies. This one is more of a comedy than a horror (which explains the good reviews given the trailer I saw in theaters); as the movie is about a wind-up monkey who plays the drums and then kills someone. The film starts off excellent with Adam Scott (*Madame Web*) showing up for a few minutes to seamlessly explain how the monkey works and sell that the film is a comedy (the priest who appears also does this as well). The various kills are crazy and over the top (the best being a swimming pool and school bus). Yet, the film can't keep up its zany premise for the entire runtime and it starts to get stale and repetitive. Theo James (*The White Lotus*) is not good enough (in a dual role) to overcome the stale parts. But there is still enough laughs and kills to make the film work. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Hulu*.
145. **Lilo & Stitch:** The film makes a few nice transitions to live-action with the final third having (mostly) similar plot points, but occurring differently; those who got pissy about the new 'ending' are the problem in society. As this accomplishes what you want a live-action remake to be: enough of the original but enough differentiation that keeps with the spirit of the original. Though going to live-action the film does lose some of the zaniness that the original was able to capture via animation. Likewise casting an actual child as Lilo doesn't quite work. Which isn't the fault of an eight(?) year-old girl, but rather a statement of fact: most child actors aren't very good. The film still comes together nicely and is an enjoyable watch. [Disney Live-action], *Disney+*.
144. **Zootopia 2:** In many ways this ranking a bit harsh. As the film only has two real flaws: the beaver character is the most god-annoying forced-workshopped character in Disney history. There is little reason for the character to exist and yet this new sidekick is there constantly to help advance the plot. (The film also forcibly brings back minor characters from the first film, but that isn't a major criticism.) The other issue is that the film explains plot points multiple times; yes it is also meant for kids so some exposition is needed. But the third time a character says they need to find the light tower so they can [spoilers] you nearly want to rage quit on the film. Yet the animation (especially the snow, fur, and when characters get wet) is rather good, though that should be expected with a budget of 150 million dollars. Ke Huy Quan (*Everything Everywhere All At Once*) is good in his new role. [Oscars – Best Animated Feature Nominee], *Disney+*.
143. **Wicked For Good:** An unnecessary sequel which adds almost nothing new (besides Ariana Grande's gorgeous minimalist wedding dress). The film wanted a PG rating to rake in even more money as the romantic relationship are toned down to the point of not caring (the 'As Long As Your Mine' number is not steamy enough). Most of the songs are completely forgettable, with 'The Girl in the Bubble' (a new song for the film) being the best, but even that is a function of the number features the best camerawork and set design of the film. The sets are often still amazing, but too often they become VFX backgrounds and that change is jarring; practical sets are great people! Perhaps the biggest issue is that once the tornado happens (conjured by an awful Michelle Yeoh machination),

the film starts to ‘un-do’ material from the original 1939 film, and despite it not being my favorite, it remains a classic for a reason. All of this forced ret-conning does not work (and everything with Nessarose Thropp/Wicked Witch of the East fails miserably). Lastly, if I have to hear, ‘back in a clock tick’ one more time, I will throw water on anyone who utters it—even Ariana Grande. [Critics Choice – Best Picture Nominee], *Peacock*.

142. **Freakier Friday:** I don’t think anyone was clamoring for a sequel, but given Lindsey Lohan has revamped her career, why not cash in? Thankfully the film isn’t a blatant cash grab, even if some of the jokes are stale (all of them regarding the vocabulary differences are awful, and so are most of the ones about Millennial therapy-speak). The plot itself is a bit basic: two single parents want to get married but their children hate each other. As to be expected Jamie Lee Curtis and Lindsey Lohan are great together. While the real find is Julia Butters (*The Fabelmans*) as one of the daughters. it is hard to tell if Sophia Hammons is good as she was required to use an awful posh British accent (seriously, filmmakers stop doing this). Another issue is that Maitreyi Ramakrishnan did not have the stage presence to convincingly play a musical superstar. Yet, it remains enjoyable and by switching the focus to two soon-to-be sisters finds enough newness to get by. [Sequel], *Disney+*.
141. **I Wish You All the Best:** Although the film is about coming out as non-binary, and not gay, the film still follows most every convention in the genre. It isn’t exactly a feel-good Hallmark film, but it at times nears it; Lena Dunham as the quirky-yet-supportive art teacher is the biggest offender. Most everything involving Cole Sprouse’s (*Suite Life of Zach and Cody*) comes off as educational for cis people. Thankfully it is well-intentioned enough that it never becomes a chore; partially due to Corey Fogelmanis (*Girl Meets World*) commitment to the leading role. [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release Nominee]
140. **Went Up the Hill:** The cinematography and set design are rather nice, and are the reason the view will lose interest ten minutes in, rather than instantly. Which, is said that the film is so languid; the premise is interesting. A recently deceased mom takes turns possessing her son and wife (while the two each attempt to process her death in their own ways). It is a premise that should absolutely work. As the script and pacing are the fault of writer-director Samuel Van Grinsven. The scenes are overly long and repetitive (how often a character takes a lengthy shower!) There was a good film here to be made, but it seems that every choice was a deliberate one to avoid being an actual horror or thriller, and instead be a poor attempt at deconstructing the genre. [AACTA – Best Cinematography Nominee]
139. **The Wedding Banquet:** An updated re-make of the 1993 original (which I should say I was not that high on). It might be that director Andrew Ahn (*Driveways*) can’t handle a crowd-pleaser? The script is not very funny. The character development is minimal; why do these characters even love each other? Han Gi-chan seems like he was cast based on his appeal to Koreans not acting talent (also the change to Korea instead of Taiwan/China was a disappointment). Joan Chen’s character is a complete caricature and that greatly detracts from the film. With all the talent involved the end result is a a bit of a dud. [GLAAD – Best Wide Release]
138. **Dragonfly:** The final twenty minutes goes completely off the rails and the film ends up raking here, instead up two(?) tiers higher (even without the ending the film is a bit slow). It is standard British kitchen-sink drama, elevated by Brenda Blethyn and Andrea Riseborough (*To Leslie*). As both are able to add in character development not present in the script. As the first 90 minutes the film does slowly build up themes of loneliness and friendship. But again, the final twenty minutes there is a massive tonal shift which does not work and essentially ruins the film. [British Independent Film – Best Joint Lead Performance Nominee]
137. **Predator: Badlands:** Once again, the only *Predator* film I’ve seen is *Prey* (also written and directed by Dan Trachtenberg). Although this installment lacks a plot as original as *Prey*, it still ends up

being an enjoyable way to spend over a hundred minutes. Elle Fanning is a delight as always; her charm really helps the film rank here. As some of the fight scenes are iffy, the VFX are nothing special, and the plot really hammers home the power of friendship. It is the plot (and its references to the *Alien* franchise) that do most of the dragging of the film down. It lets the viewer know where the film is going, multiple times, and then eventually gets there. [Elle Fanning], *Hulu*.

136. **The Running Man:** The film is a bit different than the original 1987 film, and apparently a bit closer to the source material (though the 1987 film had Richard Dawson reaching perfection as the host and showrunner). The cast assembles some big names and most do decent enough with what they are given; these aren't overly complex characters. Glen Powell (*Hit Man*) is decent, but he's been better. The parallels to current ICE enforcement are there for viewers to pick up on, but the film does not stress this at (it wants to be a highly viewed block buster). The action sequence are again decent. Decent is kinda the way to describe the film. There aren't many flaws (at least when viewing a blockbuster) but it also doesn't have the fun or enjoyability of the big-budget action films that rank higher in this tier. [Glen Powell], *Paramount+*.
135. **The Amateur:** I remember watching the trailer and thinking this could be one of the dumbest movies ever. Yet the film is far better than the trailer implies, and is a good time. It is another entry in the tech-driven espionage film, with a revenge aspect (though apparently it is a remake of a 1981 film, so I am tad concerned how much of it having a deeper plot than expected should be rewarded), though the tech/computer stuff is new. It has some things to say about morality and killing. The cast is solid, but none of the characters are deep enough to require much acting. Yet it remains an enjoyable and brisk two hours. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Hulu*.
134. **Superman:** James Gunn might have successfully revived the DCU. As he brings the right level of self-aware comedy (superheros as a whole are kinda stupid if you think about it; and he is consistently the director who gets that; *Guardians of the Galaxy*, *The Suicide Squad* and *Peacemaker*). The political commentary works; from Israel–Palestine to bots stirring up hate on social media. It helps that both David Corenswet (*Pearl*) and Rachel Brosnahan (*The Marvelous Mrs. Maisel*) are good in their roles; though Nicholas Hoult doesn't quite figure out what version of Lex Luthor he wants the character to be (the awkward Bradley Cooper cameo is perhaps the weirdest casting choice). The use of Krypto the Superdog was enjoyable, and the throwback costume was a nice touch. Even though we should be superherooed out by now, it is worth hearing out what the new DCU will become. [Critics Choice – Best VFX Nominee], *HBOMax*.
133. **Final Destination: Bloodlines:** As a fan of the first few *Final Destinations*, but also stopped watching when they got repetitive, this film is a nice return to form (even if a 50 million dollar budget still results in some cheap effects). The opening totally-not-The-Tower-of-the-Americas sequence is rather good and stylized. The plot itself works, and the kills are solid. The film often builds some tension, but rarely gets scary; it is a 'crowd-pleasing' horror. There are some plot holes and contrivances, yet they are rarely bad enough to actively harm the film. Its nice to see a fun franchise get back into form, even if I almost certainly missed a few Easter Eggs from the franchise. [Well-reviewed Horror], *HBOMax*.
132. **Kiss of the Spider Woman:** We need to stop remaking good films. The original 1985 film, despite having a few things that aged poorly, works rather well. Given the original film, this musical adaptation (of a stage musical) needs to slightly change up the plot (often for worse, but in ways that were needed to avoid being a shot-for-shot remake), along with some slight changes to reflect the original book. Neither Jennifer Lopez or Diego Luna are particularly great. Though Tonatiuh (*Carry-On*) is rather good. The sets and costumes in the musical numbers are good, but not great (partially because the camera rarely goes wide enough to allow the viewer to fully bask in the sets. Likewise the musical numbers themselves are not that good (though I assumed I missed a few reference

to Golden Era musicals; I did catch *Singin' in the Rain*). The film isn't bad, but the entire time one wishes they were watching the original; and the escapist themes rarely land. [Critics Choice – Best Costume Design Nominee], *Hulu*.

131. **The Gorge:** Although billed as an action-thriller, the film works best as a rom-com. Miles Teller and Anya Taylor-Joy are that good and charming together and communicating across the titular gorge. Yet once they go into said gorge and see what the secrecy is all about (one of them accidentally falls in) the film stops working. The effects are iffy CGI, where you wish you had strong practical sets. The themes are forced. The plot developments are neither spooky or thriller. It doesn't fall apart, but the tone shift doesn't work and the film can't sustain itself. But again the two leads are enjoyable you don't exactly care. [Critics' Choice – Best TV Movie Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
130. **Black Phone 2:** What might be a useless sequel, ends up being a worthwhile endeavor as it adds new items while expanding on the characters. The film focuses more on the sister played by Madeleine McGraw who had useful role in the first film, but easily a secondary role (the actress isn't exactly the best either). Ethan Hawke isn't given as much screentime, so he can't carry the film as much. The film also switches from being a thriller to more of a horror (while taking a lot from *Nightmare on Elm Street* and the various 80s camper-slashers). The dream sequences are rather nice visually with heightened film grain to give it an old school and eerie feel. The camp is a religious camp, and everything involving religion comes across as forced. I'm not sure if they'll be able to find a way to make a third film, but the franchise remains enjoyable. [Sequel], *Netflix*.
129. **Nobody 2:** The film didn't exactly need to be made, but it ended up having enough new material; especially the husband-wife relationship and expanded a bit on the wife's character (and perhaps hints at a potential third film in the franchise). As the other supporting characters are no longer new and do not get much expanding. Even with a new director, the film keeps most of its fun *John Wick*-esque and keeps the focus on the more absurdity of the premise. The franchise should keep going, as 90 minutes spent with Bob Odenkirk is always a good time. [Sequel], *Netflix*.
128. **Mountainhead:** Calling it *Succession*-meets-*Silicon Valley* isn't lazy when it was written and directed by Jesse Armstrong, the creator of *Succession*. Like the TV series, the film excels with solid (and specific) writing. Yes, the film is a satire of Wealthy Tech Bros, but it isn't a lazy or cheap satire. Partially due to the dialogue and partially due to assembling a strong cast of Steve Carell, Jason Schwartzman, Cory Michael Smith (*Saturday Night*), and Ramy Youssef (*Poor Things*). Those four are so strong, they overcome a lot of potential issues regarding cheap jokes. Now, the film does eventually go too far off the rails (even for a satire) in the final third, which drags the ranking down a bit. [Critics Choice – Best TV Movie Nominee], *HBOMax*.
127. **Novocaine:** For about the millionth time, I don't get the appeal of Jack Quaid (and I still watch *The Boys*!). The film works and its actually able to get a lot out of its premise (he can feel no pain) without becoming repetitive. Another mild pet peeve, the film is set in San Diego but essentially has zero feel of the city (and was apparently shot in South Africa). The film needed to end about fifteen minutes earlier, and the added twist doesn't add much. Ray Nicholson (*Smile 2*) is quite good. There are enough laughs and character development to overcome the minor flaws, and result in an enjoyable and easy watch. [Critics Choice Super Awards – Best Actor in a SciFi Movie Nominee], *Paramount+*.
126. **Thunderbolts*:** The film functions more like a *Guardians of the Galaxy* reboot than an *Avengers* reboot. As the film excels thanks to the comedic talents of Florence Pugh (*Little Women*), David Harbour (*Stranger Things*), Julia Louis-Dreyfus (*Seinfeld*), and Geraldine Viswanathan (*7 Days*). Those four are just that good, they elevate the film. As the final hour, although the themes are nice, are ones that have been done before and also done the exact way before. Yet, despite it's quality,

this isn't a sign of improvement for the MCU [Critics Choice Super Awards – Best Superhero Movie Nominee], *Disney+*.

125. **Heads of State:** A throwback to the simpler days of filmmaking: put John Cena (*Ricky Stanicky*) and Idris Elba (*The Wire*) together with revenge on their mind and a rat to find. The political commentary is too on-the-nose for the good of the film as it detracts from the escapism, while also not fitting with the comedy. But there needed to be a plot. The film is two hours of fun and two great actors having a good time. Priyanka Chopra is actually solid in a supporting role. Sit back and enjoy the fun. [Idris Elba and John Cena], *Amazon Prime*.
124. **Paddington in Peru:** This might be rated too low, but also director Paul King did not return (it was the debut feature of Dougal Wilson). And more importantly Sally Hawkins did not return as the mom. That loss was felt the most as she was the emotional center of the first two installments. Emily Mortimer (*Relic*) is decent, but that loss was too much to overcome. The film still has a fair bit of whimsy and the villains are still kooky. The characters of the kids are not as developed as in the first two films. It never feels like a cash grab, but the first two were so good, the third installment feels like a let down. [*Paddington* Franchise], *Netflix*.

Tier 10: The Better Crowd-Pleasers and Tolerable Indies

123. **Ash:** A sci-fi-horror that owes a debt of gratitude to *The Thing* and *Alien*, but never is able to stake its own claim in the genre. As the visuals are often great, but there is only so much mood lighting can do to elevate the film. Constant blue/red shots get stale despite looking good. The low-budget effects work, as even if they don't look great they look good given the budget. Eiza González (*I Care A Lot*) does a good job as the lead and shows the potential to become a star (though maybe not a high-quality actor; but the right stuff to be a star). One wishes it was more original as there were enough elements to make the film worthwhile. [Well-reviewed Sci-fi-Horror], *Hulu*.
122. **If I Had Legs I'd Kick You:** I appreciated the attempt, but the film does not work for me. It wants a surreal feeling, and the initial direction lets the viewer know it wants to be surreal (it doesn't show the daughter's face; or much of her at all). For the viewers who think that its an excellent way of showing how the mother feels towards her child (not wanting/being able to look at her) the stylistic choice could work. For me, it was a distraction that the film could never overcome (the other surrealist elements only add to my issues). The non-Conan male characters are often more of caricatures; with the fender-bender man being the worst offender. Through all of this Rose Byrne is good, and believable, but one wonders why she was the slam-dunk second-choice for awards season. The chaos becomes a chore instead of adding to the film. It tried, and it didn't exactly fail, it just did not succeed. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee], *HBOMax*.
121. **The Correspondent:** A standard journalist-arrested film. I am not sure it brings much new to the genre; beyond that this journalist did cut a few corners at times (not registering as a journalist and a mistake in a previous assignment). The flashbacks to said previous assignment do not work and result in the film being a little too long even at four hours. The film moves along from the initial arrest to the trial to the time in prison. It never commits to being one of subgenres, and as a result the film feels routine. [AACTA – Best Film Nominee]
120. **Relay:** A swift thriller that sadly has one-twist-too-many, which nearly ruins the movie. The stupid thriller cliches were avoided for 90 minutes, but the final twenty it hits nearly every one and one loses a lot of interest in the film because of it. Which is a shame as the communication via relay service was a nice touch, everything Riz Ahmed (*Fingernails*) does is excellent. Lily James (*Swiped*) is good as well. The idea behind why the film is a thriller also works: would-be whistle-blowers deciding to stay quiet, but needing to de-escalate. The airport sequence is inventive and nice. But again everything comes crashing down at the end. [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Netflix*.

119. **The Surrender:** The directorial debut from Julia Max. Except the horror film (which has some frights) never decides what it wants to say about grief and family. Does family drag you down (and into hell) or are they worth forgiving? The film bounces between the two and never takes a firm stance on the issue. The minimalism works and it helps Kate Burton and Colby Minifie (*The Boys*) are good, with Burton being the best of the two. Yet for as much as the film attempts to show why the daughter might stay around, it never solidifies why she would go along with everything; a flaw that could result in some viewers completely checking out. [Well-reviewed Horror]
118. **The Bad Guys 2:** In many ways the film is a near repeat of the first. Although the film is suppose to be about their life after trying to be good; it quickly gets a little repetitive and then the new heist begins. If anything the heists in this film, get too outlandish. And some of the social commentary from the first film is lost. Yet, the animation quality is still high, the film itself is is still fun, there are enough jokes for adults, and the voice cast is still dedicated to their performances. Yet, it lacks anything new and that hurts the overall rating, but its hard to not have fun while watching. [Annie's – Best Feature Nominee], *Netflix*.
117. **The Fantastic Four: First Steps:** Technically *Thunderbolts** is the more fun time, when it comes to MCU films this year. However, this film has the higher overall level of quality: the script is more logical (or as logical as a superhero script can be), the product design is rather good (even if some of it buying existing mid-century modern furniture to use on the sets; I love a good Womb Chair). The costumes are rather nice as well. Even if I didn't love mid-century modern the design elements would be top-notch. The cast itself is rather good, and the film doesn't treat Johnny Storm like a human douchebag like some of the previous films. The final big-bad fight fits a few too many MCU cliché's but most of that is forgiven the quality of the underlying film. [Critics Choice – Best Production Design Nominee], *Disney+*.
116. **28 Years Later:** In some ways the film serves to set up the 2026 release of *Bone Temple*, even if it works as its own installment in the franchise (and one hopes the final part of the soon-to-be trilogy pays off). The film finds a way to nicely fit into the franchise given that 28 years have now passed; it helps that writer Alex Garland returned, even if the script could have used a bit more of everything (but how much is setting up this new trilogy as Garland also wrote *Bone Temple*). The adult leads of Jodie Comer (*The Bikeriders*), Aaron Taylor-Johnson (*Nosferatu*), and Ralph Fiennes are all good (especially Fiennes). It is newcomer Alfie Williams who really shines and provides the heart of the film. And now for how Danny Boyle's grating style nearly ruins everything: far too many shots have needless dutch angles (one would assume Boyle is allergic to a camera being held square), the frame rate changes are annoying, and lastly the jarring edits are awful (especially those involving arrows thru the head (I don't care about the iPhone array that allowed them to be captured, it looks bad). If only Garland could direct the films instead of Boyle. [Critics Choice – Best Hair and Make-up Nominee], *Netflix*.
115. **Bonjour Tristesse:** A remake of the 1958 films (which I watched before seeing this one; I have not read the source material). The film is worse than the 1958 film, and one then even wonders why there was a desire to make this film. The original had some hokum, but of ten around various Production Code issues, and it then allowed for the ending to hit harder. Whereas the ending in this film lacks the emotional impact needed; as even like the 1958 version, the middle of the film bogs down a bit. The sets and costumes are nice and the film is often beautifully shot (partially because the south of France is beautiful). Yet the film rarely sells the audience on character's decisions. Claes Bang does not have the panache to play the father realistically (we need to believe he's constantly changing lovers). And I continue to enjoy the work Lily McInerny (*Palm Trees and Power Lines*) does. Yet the film does not come together as it should. [Lily McInerny]
114. **Rental Family:** A semi-hokey feel-good movie. Too much of the warm-emotions come off as forced, which is a shame as Brendan Fraser (*The Whale*) is good in the film (but also not able to carry it).

There are two main plots, meaning neither gets the full attention they deserve, while increasing the runtime to nearly two hours, and giving the film three different endings. And the two main plot points detract from developing the supporting characters at the service agency; especially Mari Yamamoto's (*Kate*) character seemed ripe for exploration (whereas the owner of the agency's character felt forced). The film is also primarily in Japanese, as a heads up. Otherwise there is a good premise, with a few laughs, but often take the easy sentimentality instead of fully developing the characters to provide deeper and more moving sentimental value. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *Hulu*.

113. **100 Nights of Hero:** The film's world and mysteries are a little underdeveloped (the titular Hero's stories also cause multiple days to be missed?), while the film's statements on women's rights are nothing new. Yet, those sins are easily forgiven with a brisk plot, and some witty dialogue. It helps that the three leads are Emma Corrin (*Nosferatu*), Nicholas Galitzine (*Red, White & Royal Blue*), and Maika Monroe (*Longlegs*). The production design, especially the stained-glass windows are great, and some of the costumes are quirky. Richard E Grant is there for all of a hot minute and is as amazing as you'd expect from him, while Felicity Jones does some nice voiceover work. [BIFA – Best Production Design Nominee]
112. **Ballerina:** A *John Wick* spin-off that eventually delivers. It takes a while for the film to get going, and there isn't much in the way of character development; Ana de Armas' (*No Time To Die*) character wants revenge on the group who killed her father (and it makes sure to remind the audience it exists in the same world as *John Wick* a few too many times. Yet once the fights get going, the choreography continues to excel and the action is there. Figure skates and flamethrowers get involved and the film becomes a fun and thrilling watch. I assume they'll make another one of these, but it will need some character development, unless it pulls out some new crazy fights/battles. [Critics Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in an Action Movie Nominee], *HBOMax*.
111. **Heart Eyes:** The film is able to combine slasher-horror and romantic-comedy tropes in a way that works (I assume I missed a few references to the *Scream* franchise). Olivia Holt (*Totally Killer*) and Mason Gooding (*Booksmart*) are both charming and their chemistry makes the rom-com aspect work. The plot itself is able to keep going despite a bunch of genre trappings, it manages to get past them. Had it been only a slasher, or only a rom-com, it would not work. By combining the genres it becomes a enjoyable experience. Which shouldn't be a surprise given director Josh Ruben (*Scare Me* and *Werewolves Within*) at the helm. [Well-reviewed Horror], *Netflix*.
110. **The Housemaid:** Paul Feig directed two movies this year: *Housemaid* and *Another Simple Favor*. What is hilarious is that both are 'sequels' to *A Simple Favor* (okay, this film is not a sequel, but if I briefly described the plot of each you'd have a hard time not confusing the plot elements). And thankfully this film captures the fun and suspense of *A Simple Favor*. The film is a tad long, and wastes time with a few too many flashbacks and narrations. Yet none of that matters much, because the movie is fun. A sequel is in production with Sydney Sweeney reprising her character, and I'll happily watch it. [Well-reviewed Thriller]
109. **The Best You Can:** A sorta-standard film, that is propped up by Kevin Bacon and Kyra Sedgwick. The script itself features a few nice jokes, and generally it hits the various heart-warming tropes. Except for the third-act fallout, most of these are fine and work; even crashing the wedding works. Again, real-life couple of Bacon and Sedgwick are great together in the film. Some of its themes on parenting and marriage get too heavy-handed, but the film never takes itself seriously enough to where the heavy-handedness becomes patronizing. It's that perfect easy-watch that sets out and accomplishes exactly what it wanted to. [WGA – Best Streaming Nominee], *Netflix*.
108. **Dangerous Animals:** For as silly a shark-based serial killer sounds a plot, the film does work. Jai Courtney (*The Suicide Squad*) has a blast in his role and brings a level of creepiness, perversion, and respect (for sharks; not people) that elevates the character beyond a simplistic serial killer. While

both Hassie Harrison and Ella Newton are good as two potential victims. The suspense is able to be sustained for most of the film, even if characters make common mistakes when trying to escape (if you've temporarily knocked him out and have open handcuffs... use them on him!). But these errors are forgiven as the brisk sub-100 minute runtime keeps the actions moving along [AACTA – Best Actor Nominee], *Hulu*.

107. **Highest 2 Lowest:** For the love of Christ, why do people keep remaking Kurosawa films? *High and Low* is far superior and nailed its themes. This Spike Lee (*Da 5 Bloods*) only nibbles at the themes; keeping the first half rather similar, but making predictable changes to the second half (the film actually works best about Spike Lee embracing that this is the end of his career and needing to get back to basics). Obviously the second half can not proceed the same, as in the original solid police work solves the case; that can't happen in a 2025 film about the Black experience. Spike has injects his trademark too-obvious dialogue and sets. The worst offender being a 17-year-old boy having a Kamala Harris 'Forward' poster in his bedroom. That is not thoughtful/realistic production design its being political to be political. The editing was often annoying. The final conversation didn't hit home. Too much of the action was non-sensical. [Black Reel Awards – Outstanding Film Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
106. **Sister Midnight:** The film could almost be described as an Indian Wes Anderson with its framing and camera movement. Except the film's narrative isn't up to par; the fantastical elements rarely land and there is rarely a driving force in the narrative. As too often the film bounces around from situation to situation with the alleged string of the bad arranged marriage tying them together; yet they are rarely tied together nicely. However, the filmmaking is so thoughtful and stylistic from debut director Karan Kandhari along with the performance Radhika Apte (who has only done a few spares English-language films). [BAFTA – Outstanding British Debut Nominee], *Hulu*.
105. **The Queen of My Dreams:** The film starts out with potential before turning into a generic mother-daughter differences film. Thankfully Amrit Kaur is a delight in a dual role as the daughter and the younger version of her mother (which absolutely works as the film uses a movie with a similar plot line of actors playing multiple characters as a through-line). The costumes are often great/colorful. The film also keeps a delicate balance of comedy and drama. But the payoff never quite comes after it gets bogged down by rehashing similar themes (it doesn't matter that this is a Muslim religious difference instead of a Christian one; its a theme we've seen before). [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release Nominee]
104. **Eephus:** The film absolutely nails the details of rec-league baseball, and that is its greatest strength; the tiny details are spot on. However, the characters are never developed and the plot rarely goes anywhere (and if anything it gets a bit nonsensical towards the end). The minimalist approach nearly works, with some former professional players and announcers included (and also a few actors from *Uncut Gems*). Yet, the film never takes advantage of its premise and fully delivers on the potential. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee]

Tier 9: The Best Crowd-Pleasers and Indie Animation

103. **Lesbian Space Princess:** The first of two back-to-back independent animated films that are difficult to rank. This film has some excellent gags and has lots of fun with its titular premise, along with a lot of in-jokes regarding sexuality. Richard Roxburgh (*The Correspondent*) is funny as the Problematic Ship, while the Australian Comedy Trio of Auntie Donna might be the best part of the film the Straight White Maleians (a lot of the movie's bits start to grow old, but these three manage to ensure everything the antagonists do lands). Even at 90 minutes, the film drags at times, and it can't keep up the frantic pace and jokes. If the repetitive in-jokes become grating the film can move

down a tier, if one loves them it could possibly move up a tier. Oh and the soundtrack rocks. [AACTA – Best Indie Film]

102. **Boys Go to Jupiter:** A quirky low-budget animated film. Once one accepts the animation quality, and then funny shortcuts it allows: people taking up all of the car window, only eyes at the door, etc the cheapness ends up working in the film's favor. And despite the budget, the colors of the film are often great, giving Florida a pastel-but-neon feel. The social commentary often lands. But the main appreciation is how quirky and unique the film is. There are not many (animated) films like this one. So despite the film often feeling episodic, and points not exactly coming together cohesively, that it ends up being like nothing else on the list, allows it to rank here. Oh and the soundtrack rocks. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee], *HBOMax*.
101. **My Dead Friend Zoe:** The dark humor surrounding PTSD mostly lands, often because Natalie Morales is so good in her role as the titular dead friend. Utkarsh Ambudkar (*The Broken Hearts Gallery*) also provides some laughs in a supporting role. The film never quite gets at the truly dark aspects of PTSD, and one wishes it did a little more digging in that regard as it would have been able to balance out with the comedy. Likewise the film doesn't dig deep enough with its themes of class and race; the ideas start being there but are once again only scratched at. The ending does hit its mark, and will pull at heart-strings. A few more jokes and a bit deeper character development and this could have easily moved up a tier or two. [Black Reel – Outstanding Hair and Make-up Nominee]
100. **Influencers:** I am not sure the first film needed a sequel (it ranked about 90th in 2023), but for the most part the sequel works; moving from critiquing instagram influencers to podcasters and the manosphere. Once again Cassandra Naud is a delight and carries the film (along with returning director Kurtis David Harder's visual flourishes). The final third gets a little iffy (what hacker leaves a computer unlocked? I don't care how secluded the home is). And once again, the film is more of a thriller and not a horror despite how much they try to still market it as one. [Sequel]
99. **40 Acres:** Another entry in the post-apocalyptic farming genre. Danielle Deadwyler (*The Piano Lesson*) is able to keep the film going as, it often falls into genre tropes (the spices are a bad offender; the crop failures means they can still manage to grow corn, but not oregano? the thing you can grow in a pot in your kitchen near a window) along with some weaker dialogue. Likewise Michael Greyeyes (*The Wild Indian*) is always a delight. The lush outdoors cinematography also helps the film thru the various lulls. Kataem O'Connor has the potential to be the breakout star of the film, though that is more projecting future potential, not that this was a star-turning performance. [Black Reel – Outstanding Director Nominee], *Hulu*.
98. **Good Fortune:** The directorial debut of Aziz Ansari (*Parks and Recreation*) who's strength ends up being Keanu Reeves' (*Always Be My Maybe*) performance—not Ansari's or Seth Rogan's. Reeves steals every scene he is in. The underlying film is a bit bland, and in-your-face about the gig economy (and homelessness which will always be a pet peeve of mine). Thankfully the hour-forty runtime means the film never overstays its welcome. When it comes to Ansari's future as a writer-director, he needs to tighten up the script, as he might not have Keanu to come and save his film next time. [Well-reviewed Comedy]
97. **Lost in Starlight:** A Korean animated film, with solid two-dimensional animation, but the few computer animated sequences are a bit poor. The film does also play fast-and-loose with the physics (for a movie about space one wish they stayed a bit more realistic). And yet, these issues can be easily forgiven because the romance-plot absolutely works. It helps that the film is about two grown and adults (something often lacking in animated love stories). Each character is well developed, and the relationship naturally progresses. The film contains many heart-warming romantic moments:

umbrella, ‘walking’ with fingers on a railing, a day at the beach, etc. These moments are tender and make the film work. [Annie’s – Best Independent Film Nominee], *Netflix*.

96. **Deep Cover:** A funny film about improvers-turned-undercover-cops. The jokes often land, though the Alexander Owen supporting cop character works better if you haven’t seen the new *Naked Gun* as his deadpan stupid jokes aren’t as funny. Orlando Bloom has lots o fun with his character, while Nick Mohammed essentially plays a version of his *Ted Lasso* character. I still do not know why Dallas Bryce Howard is cast in things, as although she isn’t bad, she can’t carry the film. There isn’t much in the way of grand themes, but enough laughs and character develop for an enjoyable watch. [WGA – Best Streaming Film], *Amazon Prime*.
95. **The Accountant 2:** I couldn’t believe the first film came out over eight years ago, as it was a shockingly good time. And this film continues with the fun. It is a little less suspenseful and instead leans into the buddy-film with Ben Affleck and Jon Bernthal getting along perfectly; a scene in a country bar is a good time. The surrounding plot is developed enough and expands on the world built in the first film (especially with the Harbor Institute). Despite an over-two-hour runtime the film rarely feels long; basically because Affleck and Bernthal are that good together. [Sequel], *Amazon Prime*.
94. **Eternity:** The concept is fun and works: you can pick where to spend eternity, but once you pick you can’t change. And to complicate matters for Elizabeth Olsen’s character she has two husbands (one who died shortly after they married). Whereas both Miles Teller (*Whiplash*) and Callum Turner (*The Boys in the Boat*) aren’t good enough to keep up with her. The ending of the film is too prolonged; had it been an exquisitely edited montage the themes would have hit even harder and cut over ten minutes from the runtime. As the film didn’t need to be almost two hours; and the padded runtime also results in more time between jokes hampering the comedic themes of the film. But even with some bloat it does nail a lot of its themes regarding love. [Critics Choice – Best Comedy Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
93. **Roofman:** Finally a movie daring enough to ask the viewer: would you risk prison to be with Kristen Dunst! (The answer is yes.) The movie hinges on Channing Tatum’s undeniable charisma and fun (can we get him and John Cena in a movie together?), as the film hits a lot of plot standards. The production design and costume design are good as it brings the feel of the early-00s, but it does not fully encapsulate the time period. The support cast is often a delight, with LaKeith Stanfield and Peter Dinkledge being the two best (and Jimmy O. Yang is good in a bit role). Enjoy Tatum being charming for two hours. [Independent Spirit – Supporting Performance Nominee], *Paramount+*.
92. **The Lost Bus:** One does wonder how much of the film was dramatized for additional suspense vs being true to its real-life source material. And the film runs into too many disaster film genre tropes; everything about Matthew McConaughey’s character (both as a father and a son) have been done a million times over. McConaughey is such a talented actor he is able to get a lot more out of the character than most. Director Paul Greengrass (*News of the World* and *Captain Phillips*) is often able to keep the tension high, even if the film could have been shorter; the bus is put into peril a few too many times, and again some of the character development is trope-y. The VFX and feeling of the fire spreading is why you watch. They are that good, and that realistic. Few films capture the intensity and speed of a wildfire. The smoke, the flames, the embers are all done with scary-yet-realistic accuracy. [Oscars – Best VFX Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
91. **How to Train Your Dragon:** A near-impossible film to accurately rank. The this is quite nearly a shot-for-shot remake of the beloved original animated film, and for the first thirty minutes that is all the viewer is reminded of. Yet, once the film gets going, one remembers why the original was so good and that watching it ‘again’ is a good use of your time. So this film ends up being enjoyable because it is essentially the original all over again. It helps that Mason Thames (*Black Phone 2*) nails the

leading role a Hiccup. The sets and costumes are okay, while the dragons do look good. One hopes for the next installment they attempt to be a little more innovative with the plot. [BAFTA – Best VFX Nominee], *Netflix*.

90. **F1 the Movie:** When the film is about racing; its ins-and-outs both is strategy, engineering, and race craft the film absolutely works (it does help that I love racing). Yet any drama and character development ends up being a chore. Of course Brad Pitt is charming, and Kerry Condon is always great and underappreciated. Yet the other secondary characters are not developed, but rather included for cheap emotional button pushing (staring at your tire changer). All of the issues regarding ownership of the team are a chore and an active distraction. The technical aspects and editing are often good, but the film can't overcome the fact its trying to be an advertisement for Formula 1 (and we'll ignore the whole finale in Abu Dhabi being some super meta sportswashing); as the film was intended to appeal to American viewers who might have been losing interest in F1 after Covid, or those who've been interested but never committed to the sport. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *AppleTV+*.
89. **The Phoenician Scheme:** The issue is that Wes Anderson has now made this movie about four-straight times (*The French Dispatch* and *Asteroid City*). The pacing and sets and colors and framing and visual gags are exactly what you'd expect from a Wes Anderson film. Yet here the jokes are not plentiful enough. The statements on religion do land, but not in a way to make up for the films plot holes (and although not pure vignettes, the plot is structured into episodes). Part of the issue that Benicio del Toro does seem to match what is needed out of a Wes Anderson film (in his defense this is the first time the main character is extremely calm). The breakout star is Mia Threapleton (*Kate Winslet's daughter*), and the rest of the ensemble is the litany of Anderson regulars. The movie is still well-made, but the formula is tarding to get stale. [Critics Choice – Best Comedy Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
88. **Fackham Hall:** *Downton Abbey* meets Zucker, Abrahams and Zucker-style comedies. A combination that works, though at times the film is a bit too interested in the plot and love story than the sheer stupidity. As the film lands multiple stupid jokes (it is a shame it was released the same year as the new *Naked Gun* as some of its thunder was probably stolen). However, whereas *Gun* was a little over 80 minutes, this is over 90 minutes, and it does end up dragging. Likewise, the film does not completely lean into the absurdity meaning it is hard to keep one-uping the previous jokes and 'stakes'. The film also assembles a great cast, and listing them out would take up far too much space. [Well-reviewed Comedy], *HBOMax*.

Tier 8: Better Indies and Not-Nomination-Worthy Dramas

87. **The History of Sound:** Directed by Oliver Hermanus, the film contains some of the same issues as his previous WWI-LGBT film *Moffie*; which often boils down to the slow pacing and over-reliance on subtleties. Thankfully, Paul Mescal is decent, while Josh O'Connor (*Challengers*) steals every scene he is in. O'Connor's performance moves this up at least a tier. The costumes are good, the sets are decent, while the lighting and cinematography could have been better. Both Hadley Robinson (*Anyone but You*) and Emma Canning decent in small supporting roles. Yet the film drags on too long; especially the epilogue and never hits its themes regarding love and music. [GLAAD – Outstanding Wide-release Nominee]
86. **East of Wall:** There is a growing trend of borderline-documentaries being filmed in the Dakotas with non-actors essentially playing themselves. Not sure why this location is so ripe for these stories, but its an interested trend. This is yet another example of these films. And it is one which could easily fall into genre trapping about losing the family farm, but instead it manages to avoid them (perhaps by the quality of non-actors; even if the best performance is by professional actor Jennifer

Ehle (*She Said*)), though as a result the film does bog down frequently. The end result is a solid portrayal of loss and found-family. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *Netflix*.

85. **A Nice Indian Boy:** First, I should assume that some of the Bollywood references went over my head (and were the reason for the unnecessary dance number near the end). Karan Soni (*7 Days* and *Deadpool*) is solid in the leading role, while having good chemistry with Jonathan Groff (*Frozen*). The film has a few nice jokes and it works as a rom-com. Yet, it still falls into a multitude of genre trappings; the break-up; the parents with their own marital issues, etc. Sunita Mani (*Spirited*) is good as the sister, and her character does add to the plot, though one wishes she got a scene to herself. It is well-made feel-good fun. [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release], *Hulu*.
84. **Together:** Billed as a horror, and it is only at times a body-horror, and even there most of the scares do not work. It is more a a relationship drama, with some comedy in there as well. Part of the reason it does not work as a horror is that the film gives away the mystery in the opening sequence (though there is a slight twist later on). As it does work as a character study on a bad co-dependent relationship, with the nice twist of the in-real-life married couple Alison Brie and Dave Franco playing the characters. The themes land, but could have landed a bit better, as once again the film is a tad too upfront, when being more mysterious would have improved the movie. [AACTA – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.
83. **Song Sung Blue:** This is not a Neil Diamond biopic, but a biopic about a couple who start a Neil Diamond impersonator band (I assume the advertising was a tad coy about that). Yet, if you like Neil Diamond, the film mainly works because Neil Diamond is great and has more music than ‘Sweet Caroline’ (as the movie frequently reminds the audience). The production design is rather good as it nails the early-90s Midwestern aesthetic. Kate Hudson’s (*Glass Onion*) accent also helps. She is good and has a few Oscar-reel moments, but her nominations seem to be rewarding her taking on more serious roles and being good in them. Hugh Jackman continues to live to do musicals and has fun rocking out. The film does hit a few too many biopic standards, and the second half has a few lulls. The film also takes some liberties with their life, few of which improve the film. [Oscars – Best Actress Nominee], *Peacock*.
82. **Hedda:** I am not familiar with the famous source material, and that perhaps took away some of my enjoyment (a lot of the reviews will mention how well-done the modernization was, and that it found new things to say). Hildur Guðnadóttir’s (*Joker*) score is often annoying, especially early on in the film. Tessa Thompson (*Passing*) choosing a grating (and fake) British accent (and don’t give me it’s suppose to be a tad fake because she is a fake person. No. Sound normal.). These three things do conspire to nearly take me out of the film completely from the start (combined with a few fish-eye shots) and nearly tanked the film’s ranking (if anything it still should be in the below tier). Yet the costume and production design are both solid, the character development works; the second half of the film does work. But the first half took too much tolerating for the film to have a chance. [Independent Spirit – Best Lead Performance Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
81. **Mother of Lies:** These Adams Family (*The Deeper You Dig*, *Hellbender*, and *Hell Hole*) indie horrors are always a delight. Their cinematography (which they do themselves) is better than most professional films; they frame and light shots perfectly, and nearly every time. The dialogue in this one is a tad weak, while dad John and daughter Zelda give weaker performances compared to their other films. The practical effects by Trey Lindsay are consistently good in these films. The film is a bit slow, and the scares are not there (folk horror really has a hard time with the scares these days). Yet, the ending does pay off. Like at the end of each of these, I can’t wait to see what they make next. [Well-reviewed Horror]
80. **Urchin:** One that is a tad difficult to rank, for me. As living in California, my ability to sympathize with the homeless has been depleted. A movie where bad things happen to the homeless drug addict,

can not elicit any sympathy from me (and if anything angers me that the (British) government is offering him assistance). Thankfully, Frank Dillane (*Harvest*) is excellent in the leading role that he can make the film worthwhile on his own. It is a star-turning performance. Likewise, actor-turned-debut-director Harris Dickinson (*Babygirl*) does a solid job behind the camera; nicely combining some surrealist elements. But can we please stop making movies about the homeless, unless they are about how they ruin our great cities. [British Independent Film – Best British Independent Film Nominee], *Hulu*.

79. **Tornado:** A slow-burn samurai movie that excels thanks to its cinematography and production design. Robbie Ryan's (*Marriage Story* and *Poor Thing*) cinematography is absolutely gorgeous capturing the rolling hills and forests; often time in low light. The film is beautiful; the details of the carnivals wagons are perfect. Jack Lowden (*The Outrun*) and Tim Roth are both delightfully sinister in their roles. Although the film can drag at only 90 minutes the visuals carry the film over the lulls. It took writer-director John Maclean (*Slow West*) ten years to make another film but the wait resulted in another solid production. [British Independent Film – Best Costume Design Nominee], *Hulu*.
78. **The Ballad of Wallis Island:** A small, heart-warming British comedy that avoids most of the genre pitfalls (despite landing in one or two). The script from Tom Basden and Tim Key (who also both co-star) has many dry British jokes (the phone booth bit might be the best). Tim Key especially is able to sell most of the jokes by playing the well-intentioned-but-bumbling lotto winner. It needed the songs to be better for the film to truly excel (as it is about a former folk-rock duo 'reforming' for a 'gig'). Carey Mulligan is always a delight. Its a brisk, well-made film. [BAFTA – Best Adapted Screenplay Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
77. **Mickey 17:** Bong Joon Ho (*Snowpiercer*, *Okja*, and *Parasite*) can really only make one movie. When it lands, it is excellent. When his commentary on wealth and oppression get too in-your-face it ends up being a mess. *Mickey 17* falls into the mess category. Robert Pattinson is good in a dual role (both 17 and 18), though his accent as 17 is a tad grating. Every scene involving Mark Ruffalo and Toni Collette is beyond grating as they over act; Bong Joon Ho has trouble directing comedy and the film is meant to be a dark-comedy. The production design is also a bit of a miss. Anamaria Vartolomei and Patsy Ferran (*Living*) are the best two actors but are in tiny roles. The film is never bad, rather its themes are too up-front and the comedy rarely lands. [Critics Choice Super Awards – Best SciFi Movie Nominee], *HBOMax*.
76. **Good Boy:** In some ways, the film's popularity was the worst thing to happen to it. As the film is not *that good*. What it does is make pet owners go, 'awwww'; its not quite blatant 'fan service', but it comes awfully close to it. Now, the premise itself is audacious and should be heralded: a horror from the prospective of a pet. Now, the film sets the stage for multiple causes of the horror: haunted house, family trauma, self-harm/drug use, illness. However, by trying to keep the audience guessing as to what the 'monster' represents, the film loses its way and can never put the pieces back together. The premise itself becomes squandered and then requires, 'aren't dogs cute' to get by. There was a really interesting film here to made, and a decent one was produced. But there was too much left unexplored. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *Hulu*.
75. **Sovereign:** Nick Offerman gets to play a more radicalized (and bad) version of his *Parks and Rec* character. It was a great casting, and he does a solid job in the role. Jacob Tremblay (*Room*) takes on a more serious older-teen role in a nice career change-of-pace. The film is based on a true story, but in do doing ends up needing to bend the character of the son in ways that become jarring as the film is more about the son slowly 'learning' about his father's 'craziness' and wanting to have a more mainstream childhood. Yet, there is a scene which should be the end of the relationship, but the son stays (and one needs to believe that the mentioning of how sister dying shortly after childbirth

and the aftermath is enough to not only keep him tagging long, but also flipping his belief; it nearly ruins the movie). The Dennis Quaid character is a bit shoe-horned into the film, even if it allows for more statements on fatherhood and raising children to be made. But it still comes across as a bit too forced. It still remains a solid film about sovereign citizens and how crazy they are. [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.

74. **Is This Thing On?:** Making a film about divorce leading someone to stand-up comedy means the instant comparisons to *The Marvelous Mrs. Maisel*. And this film does little to distinguish it from *Maisel* or other films about stand-up comedy. By time the film does distinguish itself, it is more than halfway over; it eventually does find new things to say about divorce, relationships, and reconciliation; it takes too long to get to those new points. Especially when time is spent on supporting characters (one of whom is played by Bradley Cooper who also directs the film). Will Arnett (*Arrested Development*) is good, but it is easy to see why he never got a nomination. As is now almost obligatory in my reviews; if a film decides to use ‘Under Pressure’ said use is going to be inferior to *Aftersun*. As the film is technically well-made; Cooper has lots of extended tracking shot and a few nice edits. But there is a reason it ends up in this tier of well-reviewed films that didn’t earn nominations. [Bradley Cooper], *Hulu*.
73. **Materialists:** Celine Song’s follow-up to *Past Lives*, shows she is great at making relationship dramas. Except this one at times veers into rom-com territory and when it does it falters a tad. Where it goes the worst is the constant commentary on the current dating culture. It really hammers it home, multiple times, and each time it gets more annoying. It nearly ruins the movie. Thankfully, Song’s dialogue is often great; with the three leads of Dakota Johnson, Chris Evans, and Pedro Pascal delivering the lines perfectly. Shabier Kirchner’s cinematography is also excellent; with excellent framing and lighting of the characters. Song’s second film shows she is still talented, but some of the luster from *Past Lives* could be starting to wane. [Celine Song], *HBOMax*.
72. **Peter Hugar’s Day:** Mildly experimental, and often a chore; the film is based off a transcript of a recording of the titular Peter Hugar recounting the events of yesterday. As it gets slow (at 76 minutes), and trite. It is worse if you are not an expert of the 70s NYC art as most of the film is name-dropping. And because it is a recounting of a single day, the film has no central tension holding it together; so even if the events reveal something about the character of Peter Hugar (a famous photographer), unless one is interested in his life, the sprawling anecdotes are not worth listening for this long. Which is sad, as Ben Whishaw (*Paddington*) is great; he rambles on naturally. The cadence is perfect and sustained. The 16mm cinematography and sets look nice. But there is not enough to justify 76 minutes of film. [Independent Spirit – Best Feature Nominee]
71. **Friendship:** At time the film feels like an overly long skit from *I Think You Should Leave*, though it was written and directed by Andrew DeYoung; Tim Robinson is one of the co-leads. One wishes it was funnier, even if Tim Robinson is able to sell a lot of the jokes. The film wants to say a lot about male loneliness, but few of the themes land; in part because the wife is played by Kate Mara (*Chappaquiddick*) is so amazing one wonders why anyone would feel lonely around her (they do attempt to sell it by saying she recently survived a cancer scare; and one character points out how silly it is that the husband isn’t there for her 24/7). The film is still decent, but one wishes the parts came together better. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film], *HBOMax*.
70. **Fairyland:** The film, often does not bring much new to the coming-of-age-with-a-gay-father subgenre. It has the standard plot of not-knowing, to shame, to acceptance. And of course it is set in the 70s and 80 so one know how it will end. Except Scoot McNairy (*A Complete Unknown* and *East of Wall*) is great as the father, while both Nessa Dougherty and Emilia Jones are great as his young (and then high-school/college-aged) daughter. The sets and scenes feel lived-in that despite wanting to describe the film as routine falls flat. [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release Nominee]

69. **Arco:** This French animated film, does regurgitate a lot of themes we've seen before about loneliness and technology (the three brothers posing at the potential guys are perhaps the most throwback to the bumbling villains of 90s-era cartoons). While the robots often remind the viewer of *The Iron Giant*. The 2-D animation is often rather nice (again the entire film often feels like a throwback). Yet the semi-generic plot and characters we've seen before hampers the film from truly excelling. I won't spoil the ending, but the ending does land and brings a conclusion to the film that is justified. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee], *Hulu*.

Tier 7: Good-Enough Indies

68. **Die My Love:** Co-written and directed by Lynne Ramsay (*We Need to Talk About Kevin*), the film veers too far into Art House, which destroys the pacing. Had the film toned down some of abstract scenes and provided some bare bones plot construction this would easily move up a tier. Jennifer Lawrence is good, but the set up of the film doesn't truly allow her to shine. Robert Pattinson is solid as well, though his character is often written poorly (he does just about everything wrong as the husband). Yet when everything unfolds and comes together there is a solid film to be had. But said reward is such a chore to get to. [Golden Globes – Best Actress in a Drama Nominee]
67. **The Smashing Machine:** Written and directed by Benny Safdie (*Uncut Gems*) one wonders why he felt the need to even make the film. There is little drama; characters get some development, but the development never amounts to much drama. The domestic climax isn't that strong and further ruined by an obnoxious playing of *Jungleland*; which is sad as the film tried to foreshadow it with a previous door breaking sequence and a scene with a knife. The music choices are often lazy and makes the entire project feel like a mediocre Martin Scorsese impression. Dwayne Johnson (*Jungle Cruise*) is good, but not great. He deserves a positive review, but not a Best Actor nomination. The film adds almost nothing new to the fighting genre (it is about the early days of MMA/UFC), nor opioids. The production design is solid and nails the late-90s, the same can be said for some of the costume design; especially Emily Blunt's (*Jungle Cruise*) white dress (and not to mention the heavy-lifting done by her push-up bra). The film is never bad, and contains good elements. Yet, there is never any drama or developed themes, leaving the whole project to come across as a bit of nothing. [Oscars – Best Makeup Nominee], *HBOMax*.
66. **A Little Prayer:** A film with such potential, and it can't quite deliver on it. David Strathairn is decent, while Jane Levy (*Atropia*) is the best part of the film and one wishes the film focused more on her character instead of her father-in-law (her scene at the clinic is the best in the film). The film also goes over the top (everything involving Anna Camp's (*Pitch Perfect*) character) too often. As the focus on father-in-law and daughter-in-law in a found-family film absolutely works, and it has enough around it to work, but the supporting ideas and characters are not written with enough depth to work. Which is sad, as the bones were there for the film to rank much higher, but the writing was not up to it. [Independent Spirit – Best Supporting Performance Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
65. **A House of Dynamite:** A film that is difficult to review without spoilers. As the film makes a decision at the end which moved it down two whole tiers. But that is a massive spoiler. Prepare to be let down. Likewise, the first forty minutes are really good, the second forty are good, but the final forty get repetitive. It starts strong out of the gate, but it can't keep up. Kathryn Bigelow (*The Hurt Locker*) still can direct a thrilling movie, and there are many times the viewer is on the edge of their seat. But it eventually bogs down, and no amount of A-listers showing up in small roles can keep the action up. And again, a better ending, greatly moves this film up the rankings. [BAFTA – Best Editing Nominee], *Netflix*.
64. **The Accidental Getaway Driver:** The film is mostly in Vietnamese and is the first film from director Sing J. Lee (no relation). The film has its standard characters in the prison escape genre:

the ruthless mastermind, the awkward shy one with a chip on their shoulder, and the well-meaning one. And yet despite the standard convention, each of those characters end up being well-developed; having the film be in Vietnamese helps here as one of the character has a poor grasp on the language as we was never taught it by his parents. The themes of family and loss are well done as well. [Sundance – Best Director]

63. **Jay Kelly:** Co-written and directed by Noah Baumbach (*Marriage Story*), the film needed a re-write and twenty-five minutes cut from its over two-hour runtime. Laura Dern's character does not need to exist, which is not shade towards Dern but rather the script. George Clooney, quite literally, plays George Clooney and does a good job, because he is George Clooney after all. Adam Sandler is decent, but not worth award consideration. The film itself was obvious Oscar bait, given it is about being a movie star, and some of the points land, but the runtime means too often the film bogs down, and it tries to hit too many points instead of going deeper into a specific few (for example, the relationship with the eldest daughter is done great, but also shoehorned into a subplot involving a former friend). Given everyone involved one would hope that the film came out slightly better. [Critics Choice – Best Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.
62. **Mr. Burton:** About the early life of Richard Burton, the star is his mention played by Toby Jones (*First Cow*). Whereas Harry Lawtey (*Joker: Folie à Deux*) can't quite live up to playing Richard Burton (though who could). The film excels as a mentorship study, and pondering how many people fall through the cracks due to a lack of mentorship; Richard Burton was one of the greatest actors ever and he almost turned into a coal miner. The final act, which is a jump forward in time, does not really work (and most of the film's themes had been wrapped up). Partially as the jump leaves out so much of his life after the first 90 minutes covers about a year. [BAFTA – Outstanding British Film Nominee]
61. **The Knife:** A film with a simplistic premise: a black family experiences a break-in and the cops are then called. The interrogations led by Melissa Leo form the plot, which the various family members trying to hide the truth. As the film excels by not letting any character off the hook. There are no good guys and no bad guys. The cops are at times nice (coloring with a child), at times racist, and at time corrupt. But the black family doesn't get off scot free either in their character development. What could have been a lazy cops-bad film turns into something more by debut director Nnamdi Asomugha (*Crown Heights, The Oakland Raiders*). The tension does ramp up but the pacing could be better, yet for a first-time director it is an encouraging sign. [Black Reel – Outstanding First Screenplay Nominee]
60. **Left-Handed Girl:** The directorial debut of Shih-Ching Tsou (a long time collaborator with Sean Baker who served as co-writer and editor). Admittedly, there are probably multiple Taiwan-specific customs I missed and even the left-handedness needed to drive the plot was thankfully explained in the film by the traditional grandfather. The film was shot on iPhones, and at times it showed. Both Janel Tsai and Ma Shih-yuan are rather good as the co-leads. The film doesn't exactly come together, though a charitable interpretation of character's actions does exist (combined with some knowledge of local customs I didn't have). [Critic's Choice – Best Foreign Language Film Nominee], *Netflix*.
59. **Hallow Road:** A parental-nightmare version of *Locke* helmed by Rosamund Pike (*Saltburn*) and Matthew Rhys (*Cocaine Bear*). The 80-minute runtime usually holds up without lulls, which is always the difficult part of the on-the-phone-in-the-car movies. Yet, the film has a few plot issues: the parents do not seem to be driving very fast (especially at 2am you can floor it!) given the crisis, and that the GPS shows miles while the film is set in England which uses kilometer (the speedometer is in kmph!). To appreciate the film (and not think it went off the rails) one must watch the end credits. As it really sells the themes of parenting and the central tension of protecting vs coddling

which is what makes the film work (and the performance of the leads). [Well-reviewed Thriller], *Hulu*.

58. **Bring Her Back:** The second film from Danny and Michael Philippou (*Talk to Me*), and much like their first it is well-made but not that scary. (Other people seem to like these a lot more, they must be doing something that normies end up loving as I wouldn't put either as one of the best horrors of the year; I think they explain a little too much.) The main delight is an unhinged against-type (but also to-type) performance from Sally Hawkins (*Paddington*). It was a casting coup to get her as she nails the role. Billy Barratt is also decent as the older brother. The film is creepy at times, and the themes of (found) family, grief, and parenting mostly land. [AACTA – Best Film], *HBOMax*.
57. **Familiar Touch:** The directorial debut of Sarah Friedland, about a woman with dementia moving into an assisted living facility. Although the film is not as ground-breaking as *The Father*, it still manages to avoid pitfalls while focusing on a human story. It was also apparently shot on-location at a Pasadena facility with some of the (non-dementia) residents having small roles. Kathleen Chalfant (*Old*) is good in the leading role and her performance grounds the film (when she lists off words starting with the letter 'F' might be the best scene in the film). There are rarely big moments of memory loss, instead the film smartly focuses on the everyday and adds in the memory loss (along with some of the most chill-inducing cooking scenes imaginable). Yet, at 90-minutes the film at times slows down a bit. [Independent Spirit – Best Lead Performance Nominee]
56. **Rebuilding:** Josh O'Connor (*The History of Sound*) continues to nail these meekish roles. He always manages to bring a clamming kindness to the character that allows these films to thrive where lesser actors would lean into mawkishness or require the dialogue to spell things out. The supporting cast is well rounded out with Meghann Fahy (*The White Lotus*) and Amy Madigan. It also features Lily LaTorre (*Runt, Run, Rabbit, Run*) who if they have made the move from Australia to the US to pursue acting full-time should become the in-demand child actor these next few years. The film avoids falling into conventional genre trappings, and instead ends up as a (simple) tale of rebuilding and finding one's self and found-family. Which should not be surprising given director Max Walker-Silverman's (*A Love Song*) previous work. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film]
55. **Outerlands:** In a film that could easily take cheap pot-shots about San Francisco housing costs, inequality, and loss of gay culture; to see it instead focus on the character development is a welcome surprise (while still capturing the feel of San Francisco). Some of the character development is a little basic; mainly the alcoholism (as if a unit is rent controlled, why would anyone consider leaving?). The main character of Cass is well developed and its themes of family and belonging do end up landing, especially given Asia Kate Dillon's quality performance. As the film is about a trans character, and most of the themes derive from that fact, but the film is often more interested in them as a person. [Independent Spirit – Best First Screenplay Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.
54. **Inside:** An Australian prison drama from debut writer-director Charles Williams. The film does hit some standard prison tropes, but the characters and acting more than carry the momentum. Guy Pearce (*The Brutalist* and *The Convert*) continues to churn out solid performances in Aussie films. Cosmo Jarvis (*Calm With Horses*) is a delight as the reformed(?) pedophile. Toby Wallace (*Babyteeth*) makes a brief appearance. Thanks to the performances and character development the film has enough to say about (self-)forgiveness, pre-destination, and fatherhood. Also, in a year with a literal *High and Low* remake, this film contained the best homage to the original. [AACTA – Best Actor Nominee]
53. **Sisu: Road to Revenge:** Its basically 90 more minutes of the first film with the absurdity slightly increased, so I'll literally copy-paste with a few updates. Also the film does find a good reason to exist and the Soviets stole some Finnish land after WWII. A fun bare-bones action movie. The overall reviews might be tad too generous as there isn't much to fault so its had to write a bad

review, but it is not great. The blood and guts is fun and there are interesting kills. Though there are a few absurd moments where the character should die or requires a leap of faith in plausibility (a missile won't propel a train!). Yet these are easily forgiven as the landscapes are beautifully shot. The minimalist dialogue works. And killing Soviets is always a good way to spend 90 minutes. Given the short runtime there is no padding, just a simple revenge story quickly told. Jorma Tommila is still good. [Sequel], *Netflix*.

52. **Nouvelle Vague:** Richard Linklater's love letter to the French New Wave. Which does mean at times it comes across as an almost documentary than a film with characters. The black and white cinematography looks great. I don't know if I can call the costumes great, as they are mainly recreations of those in *Breathless*. It's also hard for me to review this film, as I am not that versed in the French New Wave, and I dislike Jean-Luc Godard's films, and I do not care for *Breathless*. Given that this film is about the filming of *Breathless* some of the nostalgia falls flat on me; even if the film does show how odd Godard's work process and philosophy was (as these are the very things that result in me finding his films grating and unstructured). Zoey Deutch is solid as Jean Seberg and the same can be said about Guillaume Marbeck as Godard. [Independent Spirit – Best Supporting Performance Nominee], *Netflix*.
51. **Griffin in Summer:** Everett Blunck (who is straight out of central casting for *Young Sheldon*) is great as the titular Griffin. It is his performance that sells the film and gets the viewer hooked; his opening performance of an excerpt from his new play is hilarious and he sells it. He makes some of the offier jokes land and keeps the plot moving along. Melanie Lynskey (*I Don't Feel at Home in This World Anymore*) and Owen Teague (*To Leslie*) round out the film with solid supporting performances. The film brings enough new to say about the coming-out-genre, in part because the film is about a fourteen year old. Even at ninety minutes, there are some lulls and some repetitive sequences (the constant updating of the play's script—even if it also serves as a bookend to the film). The debut from writer-director Nicholas Colia is a solid first effort. [Independent Spirit – Someone to Watch Nominee], *Hulu*.
50. **Splitsville:** A comedy that has enough jokes to get by, but can't decide if it wants to be a rom-com or a drama when exploring issues in open relationships. As the film has things to say about being in an open relation, but it never figures out how to tie everything together. The film reunites Michael Angelo Covino and Kyle Marvin (*The Climb*), and it does continue some of their now-hallmarks: title carded sections and seemingly-continuous shots. Both Dakota Johnson (*Materialists*) and Adria Arjona (*Hit Man*) are good, though the film never quite figures out what it wants to do with Adria's character which hampers the film's final few minutes and hurts the overall flow of the film. There was something equally special here as *The Climb*, but the duo didn't figure it out this time. Oh, and there are a bunch of delightful actors in supporting roles: Nicholas Braun (*Succession*), Charlie Gillespie (*Totally Killer*), and David Castañeda (*The Umbrella Academy*). [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.
49. **Spit:** I did not know the film was a spin-off of *Gettin' Square*, which came out in 2003, so perhaps I missed some smaller plot call backs. The film is a funny crime film, with enough heart and themes to elevate itself above standard fare. The refugee crisis is smoothly worked into the plot and teaching Syrians curse words is a hilarious bit. But the reason to watch is David Wenham's (*Goldstone*) performance as the titular Johnny "Spit" Spitieri. His commitment to the physical comedy (the running in flip-flops never gets old) is commendable and he nails the right level of cooky-but-sympathetic. The film is a well-made good time. [AACTA – Best Actor Nominee]
48. **On Falling:** The British kitchen-sink poverty drama that I normally end up hating, yet this one works (perhaps because Ken Loach wasn't the director). Writer-director Laura Carreira (in her debut) is more interested in the social isolation and loss of personality. Though the 'evils' of work could be

causing these, the film never hammers home that idea; and leaves it open for the lead character to also be at fault; she has no hobbies and has a hard time connecting with anyone. Lead actress Joana Santos needs to be freed from churning out Portuguese telenovellas and get some English-language movie roles as she was great in the film. [BIF – Best Film Nominee]

47. **The Plague:** As a heads up, the film is not a horror film. It is a psychological thriller/drama. The cinematography is eerily great (perhaps why some people called it a horror); the stylized underwater shots, and the long hallways and staircases (*The Shining*-esque shots add to the miscategorization of being a horror) of the aquatic complex are gorgeous (whoever found the aquatic complex to film in deserves a raise). Kayo Martin gives an chilling performance as the lead bully of the camp; you'll never want to punch a child so much which is a credit to his breakthrough performance. Everett Blunck (*Griffin in Summer*) is rather good along with Kenny Rasmussen; this really could end up producing multiple future stars. The themes of bullying, fitting-in, and finding one's identity at the age of thirteen mainly land. The directorial debut of Charlie Polinger shows he could end up making some great films. [DGA – Best Debut Director]
46. **The Long Walk:** A large chunk of one's ranking will be how much they are able to buy into the premise: a totalitarian regime 'hosts' a yearly competition which one boy/young man from each state 'competes' to see who can walk the longest and win riches and a wish. Except the losers, though who become unable to keep walking, are shot dead in their tracks. Also the person in charge of the event is a Major (not a Colonel or a General? and excellently played by Mark Hamill). Yet, if one is able to buy the actors give such great performances resulting in a rewarding film. Cooper Hoffman (*Licorice Pizza*), David Jonsson (*Rye Lane*), Garrett Wareing, Tut Nyuot (*Steve*), Charlie Plummer (*Lean on Pete*), Ben Wang (*Mean Girls*), Roman Griffin Davis (*Jojo Rabbit*), and Joshua Odjick (*Wildhood*). It's highly likely we look back on this film one day and wonder how they assembled such a cast; it also gives the feel of a throwback 80s boy-adventure film; though with actual stakes. [Independent Spirit – Robert Altman Award]
45. **The Ugly Stepsister (Den Stygge Stesøsteren):** A new take on the Cinderella, that focuses on one of the sisters, and turns her into a tragic villain(?). As the beauty 'regimes' are forced upon her by various older women. The film does lay its themes on a tad thick (unrealistic beauty standards being the main one) and that does detract just enough to move the film down a tier. The film nails its body horror, though said horror isn't constant; limited to a few scenes. Yet one of those scenes is perhaps the most cringe-inducing one you'll all year. The sets and costumes look good and help create the film's mood. The physical transformation of the titular stepsister is why the film got an Oscar nomination. The film also is able to balance its body horror with a few laughs. [Oscars – Best Makeup Nominee], *Hulu*.
44. **Little Amélie or the Character of Rain (Amélie et la métaphysique des tubes):** Ranking the film is a tad difficult because the animation is near perfect; almost an impressionist feeling with the pinks and purples (and the greens and blues). Likewise the beams of light and condensation are often excellently done. The film looks beautiful. However, the film's plot isn't exactly fully formed and dips into surrealism/fantasy a bit too often. Now, some of the plot points, especially those regarding loss are well done. It is the overall plot that is disjoint at times. But it is all forgiven due to the quality and vibrancy of the colors. [Oscars – Best Animated Film Nominee]
43. **Avatar: Fire and Ash:** The primary issue of this three-hours-plus movie, is that it isn't a third installment, but rather a continuation of the second film. This and *Way of Water* should have been a single film (not six hours and a half hours across two movies). As the only new things are: i) a squid-like creature (I'm not counting the otters, they have not plot purpose), ii) the titular Fire tribe, iii) the trading people, and iv) a lot shots at night. And these four are not new enough to completely wow the audience with the VFX, which is what Avatar needs to excel, given the poorly

written characters. As once again Sigourney Weaver remains the only really acting (Eddie Falco, is there to have fun and give orders). Stephen Lang (*Don't Breathe*) is steadily improving as his character is basically the only one with any internal conflict and he has been able to make the most out of a tiny bit of development. Oona Chaplin (*What If...*) is also a delight as the leader of the Fire tribe. The franchise isn't getting stale yet, but the fourth installment needs to bring major new setting with completely new visuals to make up for the continued weak script and character development. [Oscars – Best VFX Nominee]

Tier 6: Good Drams and Good Laughs

42. **Dust Bunny:** Sometimes a film is so fun, it gets moved up a tier that it might not deserve. A blend of Roald Dahl, Wes Anderson, and John Wick makes for a delightful watch. The film keeps its various twists hidden under its covers, and allows the viewer to decide for themselves if there is truly a monster under the bed. As the movie is a kids movie, despite the R-rating; which is part of the fun. The kid played by Sophie Sloan and hopefully a franchise picks her up in a role as she that much of a delight. The sets and costumes are detailed and bright. The camera uses the sets to frame characters nicely. And the supporting cast including Sigourney Weaver and David Dastmalchian only add to the fun. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee], *HBOMax*.

41. **Jazzy:** The second film from Morrissa Maltz (*The Unknown Country*), and while it is a big improvement, it still has her now-hallmarks for both good and bad. A sparse coming-of-age story about a young Native American girl, the film starts off plotless and drifts thru scenes in her life. Eventually some semblance of a plot forms, but one needs to get thru the rough parts (which are often longer than they need to be and interlaced with beautiful landscape shots). Jasmine Bearkiller Shangreaux is good as Jazzy; actually the film fits in the same universe as *The Unknown Country* as Lily Gladstone reprises her leading role in that film while Jazzy had more of a bit role (my guess would be that some of *Jazzy* shared production with *The Unknown Country* as it does seem like the child actors age naturally over the course of a few years. Even if the film never makes lots of deep statements on coming-of-age its light touch works. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Award Nominee], *Hulu*.

40. **The Assessment:** An interesting-enough science-fiction film about a post-climate change society where the few remaining people can not greatly expand their lifespan via medication (though this part of the plot gets downplayed and not fully explored) with a side effect of the medication being that it becomes biologically impossible to have children. Therefore the state (another underdeveloped part of the plot; notice the theme here) assesses whether a family can have a child. Elizabeth Olsen (*His Three Daughters*) is good as the want-to-be mother, but the film belongs to Alicia Vikander (*The Light Between Oceans*) as the assessor in charge of determining if they should be granted a child. Her performance is outlandish, as required by the script. The film does not pull off the ending, even if the epilogue finally reveals more information and gives each of the three leads a suitable send-off, it is not worth the extra fifteen minutes. [British Independent Film – Best Lead Performance Nominee], *Hulu*.

39. **Black Bag:** A brisk little spy film, expertly directed by Steven Soderbergh (*Logan Lucky*); including a lengthy opening tracking shot. As expected Micheal Fassbender and Cate Blanchett are good as the married couple at the heart of the film. A spy thriller about a devoted married couple (instead of the standard backstabbing) works, and there are plenty of bread crumbs to follow. A polygraph sequence towards the end nearly ruins the entire film (but cutting it would push the runtime well below 90 minutes). Marisa Abela (*Back to Black*) is a delight and starting to put together a solid career. The rest of the cast is enjoyable, while the film is a decent entry in the modern spy thriller genre. [WGA – Original Screenplay Nominee], *Amazon Prime*.

38. **Wake Up Dead Man: A Knives Out Mystery:** Unlike previous films in the franchise Benoit Blanc is now a supporting character, while Josh O'Connor (*The History of Sound*) is the actual lead (curse you Category Fraud! and he should have gotten more support for *lead* actor). The switch to religion works, and it is a big improvement over the in-your-face *Glass Onion*; though once again the themes are still obvious (part of what made the first one so great was the slow realization the film was not actually meant to be a murder mystery). The direction and visuals are once again rather good. The ending does drag a bit, and that pads the runtime to nearly two hours and thirty minutes. Like before the cast is still stacked with Andrew Scott having the most fun and Daryl McCormack continuing a string of solid performances. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Film], *Netflix*.
37. **The Life of Chuck:** Written and directed by Mike Flanagan (*Gerald's Game*), it is a major turn away from his usual horror films and miniseries. This film is part sci-fi, musical, and drama. The strength of the film is the reverse chronological order adapted from the Stephen King source material. One imagines if the film was told in a straight-forward manner, the plot would not work as well. Similarly, the film features narration by Nick Offerman, which as the film goes on becomes more present (and I assume often lifting from the source material). The narration works given both the set up, and that it slowly ramps up in intensity; in a year where a lot of films were knocked for their voiceovers, this is one of the few that made it work properly. Also, admittedly, part of the reason the film ranks here is that it works as a feel-good film about living life; on multiple levels. Though, it is possible that the film does overboard for a few people and becomes pure hokum. [Mike Flanagan], *Hulu*.
36. **Lurker:** The directorial debut of Alex Russell (co-wrote 'Forks' episode of *The Bear*) and it is a solid first effort. The film does slightly bog down for a bit in the late-middle; it does follow the generic plot outline so the falling out has to come. The two leads of Théodore Pellerin (*Beau is Afraid*) and Archie Madekwe (*Midsommar* and *Gran Turismo*) are both rather good. Also shout out Havana Rose Liu (*Bottoms*) who's performance as the manager helps keep things together. The themes of fame, fan culture, and artistic creation land. It is a well-made debut and one should be on the lookout for what Russell does next. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature], *HBOMax*.
35. **Caught Stealing:** Darren Aronofsky (*Black Swan*) still has his distinct visual style (the shots of the alleys and courtyards are great, the camera moving through the globe in Flushing Meadows is one of the better shots you'll see this year), but the film itself isn't up to his previous efforts. The script is tight, but needed either more zaniness and character development (the Safdie Brothers have made this film multiple times now, and once this year! and Sean Baker made the comedy version last year!). Austin Butler (*Elvis*) is good in the lead role, but isn't given enough character to carry the film. Similarly, Regina King (*Shirley*) was mainly told to be angry and she pulls it off, but the character lacks much else. The cat might be the best actor in the film given the lack of character development. Aronofsky is still worth watching, but his best years might be long behind now. [Darren Aronofsky], *Netflix*.
34. **The Baltimoreans:** Jay Duplass' first solo directorial effort, and co-written with breakout lead actor Michael Strassner (the film takes multiple plot points from Strassner's life). Again, this is Jay's film; it has the trademark Duplass Brothers feel-good mildly-inspirational comedy about broken people. As watching Strassner and Liz Larsen's characters come together over the course of Christmas Eve is a delight to watch and Strassner is able to sell multiple jokes. The final third of the film does start to drag a bit, and this is perhaps where Jay Duplass' inexperience shows (though tightening it up probably still isn't enough to move it into the next tier?). The film aims small, and nails its target with two well-developed characters. [Independent Spirit – John Cassavetes Nominee]
33. **Nonnas:** One of the better feel-good films of the year. By all accounts this should be a cheesy film about opening a restaurant. Instead it is about moving-on, second-chances, (Italian) food, and found

family. And one should be suspicious given it is directed by Stephen Chbosky (*Wonder*), but this film hits all the right notes. It helps that Vince Vaughn and Linda Cardellini are great together. Throw in the titular nonnas being played by stalwarts of Italian-American cinema: Lorraine Bracco (*GoodFellas* and *The Sopranos*), Talia Shire (*The Godfather* and *Rocky*), Brenda Vaccaro (*Midnight Cowboy*), and Susan Sarandon. Sit back, and let your heart warm. [DGA – Best TV Movie], *Netflix*.

32. **Nuremberg:** Possibly the most anti-Trump film of year; and that is saying something given that *One Battle After Another* won Best Picture. As this film is not exactly about prosecuting Nazis for war crimes. It often treads just below deserving nominations in lots of categories; an Oscar-bait film that never nails its premise; partially because the dialogue is often poor and serves as exposition. Some of the costumes are great (Malek's and Crow's jackets), but the rest often fall flat. The same can be said about some of the sets and cinematography; often good, rarely great, never bad. There are few woman characters; they often serve little purpose with Lydia Peckham's journalist character being the worst offender. The film also pretends the Holocaust wasn't really known outside of Germany for drama. Yet, a well-made and star-studded film reminding us about the importance of not rounding up your own people and then the need to jail those in power who committed the atrocities hits home in 2025. [Well-reviewed Drama], *Netflix*.
31. **The Chronology of Water:** The directorial debut of Kristen Stewart is a bit experimental at times, with a semi-non-linear plot. Imogen Poots (*The Father*) finally has a chance to showcase her acting chops and was rather good. The 16mm cinematography is rather good; except for rough edges (this does not add a grittiness it is lazy/cheap filmmaking! This is a hill I will die on). Likewise the sound design is a disaster; the voiceovers are soft, high-pitched, and nearly inaudible (one of the most important scenes is ruined because the voiceover is so poorly mixed!). To make matters worse, the sound for placing objects down is cranked way up (don't give me that it shows her chaotic mental state). Again bad/needlessly grating filmmaking. Had these been addressed it ranks in the next tier, maybe even two(!). As the script does slowly reveal key plot points. John Belushi shows up for a few minutes and steals the show (and an argument could even be made for some more Supporting Actor buzz). Hopefully Kristen Stewart continues to direct film, but with more polished technical aspects. [Kristen Stewart]
30. **Eddington:** Ari Aster has certainly switched from horror to making his own kind of movie these days. The film does have too many themes and it can't get them all to land. Likewise it is neither thrilling enough nor funny enough to fully work as a satire or a western. However, it is an equal opportunity attacker; almost no political belief gets off scot-free. And it is also about a time most people probably do not want to relive. Despite all of this, it does get a lot right: phones and social media have eroded any common-sense in daily life and radicalized everyone (while also pointing out many views are not honestly-held but held for clout). That core message gets thru, even if it did not need two hours and thirty minutes to do so. Thankfully Aster's camerawork is solid as always, and all of the actors put in solid performances. [Ari Aster], *HBOMax*.
29. **Plainclothes:** The directorial debut of Syracuse-native Carmen Emmi (the film was shot in the Syracuse area and heavily features the Carousel Mall. Note: I refuse to call it Destiny USA). It provides a nice wrinkle to the coming-out genre by focusing on a plainclothesed cop who runs sting operations on gay men who eventually begins to comes to terms with his sexuality. Tom Blyth and Russell Tovey are both great, and do a lot of heavy lifting in the film; multiple scenes are the two of them with little dialogue and each of them convey the nervous energy perfectly. Carmen Emmi had one of the better debuts of the year. [GLAAD – Best Limited Release]
28. **Companion:** The less one knows going into the film the better, and therefore a proper review is difficult without spoiling the various twists and turns (which almost always work; and they are nicely set up). The film is often funny with lots of great jokes. Sophie Thatcher (*Heretic*) is great in the lead

role, and essentially carries the film. The only reason the film can't rank higher (and where the spoilers come into play) is that the film is part of a very specific sub-genre of science-fiction, and it does fall into a few genre trappings without adding enough new ideas. The film is still good, but it didn't have enough to fully elevate it. [Critics Choice Super Awards – Best Actress in a Science-Fiction Movie], *HBOMax*.

27. **Bugonia:** I have not seen *Save the Green Planet!*, the film which this is based on. That adaptation could be why it doesn't have director's Yorgos Lanthimos (*The Lobster* and *The Killing of the Sacred Deer*) usual quirkiness (it still is quirky, but not as much as one expects from him). The strengths of the film are Emma Stone (*Poor Things*) and Jesse Plemons (*Kinds of Kindness*) who carry the dialogue-heavy film. The problem is with the script; it is in-your-face with the themes and of course they are pertinent to current American society: conspiracy theory rabbit holes, Big Pharma, male loneliness, etc. These themes are not not nuanced enough to make an excellent film. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.
26. **The Naked Gun:** A film that initially would seem like a bad cash-grab, ends up being one of the funniest films of the year. The stupid, deadpan comedy to the original films is back on full display (even if some of the jokes are taken from other source: manslaughter and turkey baking. The constant coffee gags, the *Sex in the City* reference, and dear lord the ending credits (know your Netflix password people). Liam Neeson, Pamela Anderson (*The Last Showgirl*), and Paul Walter Hauser are all great in their roles. The film is 90 minutes of stupid fun. [Critics Choice – Best Comedy], *Paramount+*.
25. **On Becoming a Guinea Fowl:** Almost all of the film is in the Bemba language, and the film does heavily rely on local customs which will not be explained to the viewer, though for the most part can be inferred by those paying attention (more that the film isn't the easiest watching even ignoring the subject matter and the slow art-house pacing). As the pacing the direction nearly make the film a chore to watch, and the viewer needs to hang in. As the payoffs do eventually come with the themes of grief, family secrets, and the patriarchy. Despite the film's quality it is one that can't be easily recommended as many could walk away profoundly bored. [British Independent Film – Best British Independent Film Nominee], *HBOMax*.
24. **Blue Sun Palace:** The film perhaps should be in the next tier, as its pacing can feel glacial at times; and the plot more episodic slices of life than a fully-coherent narrative. Yet this same issues, are what makes the film work. The camera lingers and remains stationary (except for perhaps some slight panning between characters) for each scene (until the end when there is a lengthy tracking shot; an excellent use of using the now-moving camera to also convey emotion/character development). The only cuts are to the next scene. That each shot is excellently staged and framed by cinematography Norm Li. As the film allows each of the little moments to play out and eventually encapsulate the viewer, but one needs to fight thru the pacing as the reward is there. [Independent Spirit – Best First Feature Nominee]
23. **Ponyboi:** A solid film about an intersex sex worker. With the proliferation of LGBT films, intersex is a subgenre that still hasn't gotten as much attention. The film does veer dangerously close to being too-obvious but it often gets right to the edge before it stops spelling things out for the audience. Also the ending is slightly dragged out even if the film did need to wrap up the relationship between the titular Ponyboi and their father, most of the action is Ponyboi's interaction with the New Jersey underground; when that subplot is wrapped up the film could have been done. Ed Wu's cinematography is often good with great lighting. Dylan O'Brien (*Anniversary*) is electric as the pimp and drug dealer. Though the stand-out is River Gallo as the titular Ponyboi who's screen presence is amazing. [GLAAD – Outstanding Limited Release Nominee]

Tier 5: A Minor Flaw Keeps It From Being Great

22. **Presence:** Another low-budget film from Steven Soderbergh (*Kimi* and *High Flying Bird*) with him serving as both cinematographer and editor. Admittedly the editing was not much; every cut is a fade to black (which does make logical sense in the scope of the film). The cinematography is rather good as the film is told from the point-of-view of the titular Presence inside the home. The cinematography partially serves as the character development of the Presence. The cast is often rather good; Lucy Lui and Chris Sullivan are good as the parents. The teenagers are both essentially unknowns and held up their end. There are not exactly any scares, it feels more like *A Ghost Story*. The ending could have been improved slightly (but still rather good and easily elevates the film), but detailing that would mean a major spoiler. [Soderbergh], *Hulu*.
21. **Warfare:** Although co-written and co-directed by Alex Garland (*Civil War*), it is Iraq Veteran Ray Mendoza's film. At a brisk 90 minutes, the film isn't interested in grand statements on war, but accurately depicting a few hours in a (relatively minor) firefight. It is the accuracy and attention to detail that make the film succeed, combined with some character development; these aren't stand-ins but mild fictionalizations of the real members of the unit. These people are not glorified nor are they tainted, rather they (even as SEALs) respond how humans would respond in the middle of the war. The sound design is the best part (but a touch below that of *Civil War*; which again was more action-y so it could get more out of its sound design, by design). I'm not sure Ray Mendoza should be viewed as an up-and-coming director, but he deserves the chance to show what he can do, and he learned from one of the best. [Critic's Choice – Best Sound Nominee], *HBOMax*.
20. **The Mastermind:** The film is classic Kelly Reichardt (*Certain Women*, *First Cow*, and *Showing Up*), for better and worse. Her minimalist plot turns a heist film into an anti-heist film like only she could; the film is more interested in alluding to all the ways the heist will eventually go wrong and the aftermath. Except the second half of the film does start to heavily bog down and could easily dissuade some viewers. The production design and costumes are amazing and the film feels lived-in and straight from 1970. Josh O'Connor (*Wake Up Dead Man*) is a delight in an understated performance (again classic Reichardt slowly develops his character) and then the film features equally enjoyable supporting performances by Alana Haim (*Licorice Pizza*), John Magaro (*September 5*), Gaby Hoffmann (*C'mon C'mon*), and Matthew Maher (*Relay*). The film requires some patience, and perhaps the ending doesn't work (though there is an argument to be made the ending is perfect), but the payoff is there. [Reichardt]
19. **Magazine Dreams:** Although the film was ready to be released in 2023, it was delayed a few years because of star Jonathan Majors's (*Creed III*) assault conviction. Majors' performance is near-perfect (much like when he showed up to Michael B Jordan's franchise and stole the show, Majors gave the better performance by an African-American man this year; there will be a lot of salt about the Best Actor award on this list). Majors plays the bodybuilder as shy, awkward, mildly-autistic, and yet also full of rage. The performance is electric. The costume and set design are phenomenal as the film feels like it was made in the 90s, but it is set in the 2010 (all of which also add to the alienation Majors' character feels). However, the film falls apart in the second half. It attempts to cover too many social themes, and fails to realize the bodybuilding competition was the climax (a few of the next scenes could have gone before, and perhaps reached a 100-minute runtime and this film would then be up a tier (or two). But as the second half continues to drag along, one sadly starts wishing this solid film was already over. [Black Reel – Outstanding Lead Performance Nominee]
18. **Frankenstein:** The film has Guillermo del Toro's (*The Shape of Water*) classics: amazing period set-design, solid costumes, and some body horror. Dan Laustsen's (*John Wick: Chapter 2*) cinematography is often gorgeous as well. The film excels at the technical aspects of film-making; except for the VFX which often look cheap and bad—especially any that involve animals. The adaptation does stray a bit from the source material, which is fine. Instead the flaws are that the film takes too long to get its messages across, and frequently drags, before really hammering home the themes

and messages. Thankfully Jacob Elordi (*On Swift Horses*) is good and the culmination of themes isn't a total facepalm. For the big time Best Picture nominees, this is easily one of the more flawed ones that is reliant on being technically proficient for most of its status. [Oscars – Best Production Design], *Netflix*.

17. **It Was Just An Accident:** Although the film itself is rather good, one has to wonder a little bit how much of the praise is that Jafar Panahi shot the film covertly and without permits in Iran (while the film is critical of the authoritarian regime). The film benefits from lengthy takes with a stationary camera (these shots are often beautifully lit; one shot lit by a van's brake lights is gorgeous). The film also is able to get a lot out of a simple premise, by naturally adding characters to the dilemma. The character development and themes of forgiveness, or at least acceptance and moving on, do land as the film comes together. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay Nominee], *Hulu*.
16. **No Other Choice:** Despite what the trailer might imply the film is a comedy and not much of a thriller. Perhaps, that slightly affected the ranking as the film does bog down a few times and runs a bit long (but that could also be in relation to what I was expecting). Director Park Chan-wook is in his bag with flourishes: a camera on the beer mug, the most of the edits (especially one where the house becomes the bonfire), and other great camera movements. Yet, these can't fully overcome a slightly clunky plot. The film works best when it is a family drama and is at its worst when it wants to make statements about capitalism. Some of the laughs land, other do not (and I assume some I missed, and some I felt fell flat were a result of cultural differences). Lee Byung-hun is good in the leading role, but he doesn't exactly nail the bumbling idiot portion of the murder spree. The film is good, but it does not come together as well as one wishes it could have. [Golden Globes – Best Comedy or Musical Nominee], *Hulu*.
15. **Sirāt:** The sound design alone makes the film worth watching. Though hopefully you have an actual sound system as no way TV speakers (or even a soundbar) will do it justice. That's how good it sounds. The rave music could have been bass that drowns out everything, but instead it is layered and complex (with some popping bass). Likewise the cinematography is gorgeous. The shots of the desert, the dissolves with the sun, (aerial) shots at night with only the headlights showing the way. Some of the tracking shots of the cars driving and kicking up dust in the desert. The film looks and sound gorgeous. Yet what will matter for the ranking is the plot. As the plot is minimalist and things often just happen. If the viewer buys in the film probably moves up a tier. If the viewer has no buy-in it drops two(?) tiers. As the film still have multiple emotionally impactful scenes, the issue is they don't quite fit into a cohesive narrative; the randomness that some viewers will love with turn off others. [Oscars – Best Sound Nominee], *Hulu*.
14. **Father Mother Sister Brother:** A three-part anthology film by Jim Jarmusch (*Paterson*) that does a better job than most at connecting its shorts (skateboards, toasting, Uncle Bob). The quality of the individual pieces is constantly decreasing; and the first is the best written and has the best camera work, while the last features the 'worst' actors (which is more a statement of the quality of the first two: Adam Driver and Tom Waits (and Mayim Bialik basically playing her standard character); Charlotte Rampling, Cate Blanchett, and Vicky Krieps). Each does a good job of slowly revealing information; which family members are taking advantage of who; who knows about the manipulation; who is okay with it. Through its simplicity it ends up with a lot to say about family and family relations. Each segment runs a minute-or-two long, but that is forgivable. [National Board of Review – Top Ten Independent Film]
13. **Blue Moon:** When Richard Linklater and Ethan Hawke team up good things happen: *Sunrise Trilogy*, and *Boyhood*. Although nowhere near as them, it is still a good film that showcases Ethan Hawke's talent. He is tasked with playing a contemptible, pathetic alcoholic, who might also be the smartest (and best-intentioned) person in the room (*Oklahoma!* is a dog-shit musical; and dare I

even also suggest Rodgers and Hammerstein’s musicals are not that good). Hawke’s talent is able to ensure the character is able to walk the tightrope; as the audience never quite feels sorry for him, but does sympathize with him. And for a film about the theater, it does a good job of having opaqueness regarding what part of Hawke’s character is him putting on a performance for the fellow party-goers and what is his real self. The character is also aided by some great costume and set design to make him look small. Andrew Scott (*All of Us Strangers*) excels in supporting role. Margaret Qualley is in the film, but her character is a bit out of place, as Hawke’s love(?) interest; the film does set up the idea his character is gay, so that relationship does not exactly gel with the rest of the script. Anything Linklater makes is worth watching, even if the script can’t keep the energy and jokes flowing to elevate the film into a higher tier. [Oscars – Best Actor Nominee], *Netflix*.

12. **Twinless:** The second film from writer-director-actor James Sweeney (*Straight Up*; a film I had in my top-five for 2020). He continues to be an underrated gem, though this film got more award recognition. Perhaps because Dylan O’Brien (*Saturday Night* and *All Too Well: The Short Film*) is the co-lead and rather good (in a dual role as the twins). While James Sweeney is the co-lead of is new-found friend. There are two excellent cinematic moments; the leaving of multiple voicemails, and the split-screen at the party (the shots under the covers are also nice). The jokes are good, but there needed to be a few more to jump into the next tier. The film’s lengthy opening (multiple scenes before the credits) works and is a good directorial decision (and the ending is a nice and subtle bookend). Sadly the film hits a few too many tropes for it to truly excel, even though its themes on loss and friendship are well-done. James Sweeney remains great. [Independent Spirit – Best Picture Nominee], *Hulu*.
11. **The Testament of Ann Lee:** This time Mona Fastvold directs with spouse Brady Corbet co-writing (*The Brutalist*; where their roles were switched). Like their previous film together it has a lot it wants to say about the American experience, this time about the early Americans—in particular the religious crazies who wanted space to practice in their own way away from England. Amanda Seyfried (*Mank*) is good, not great, as the titular Ann Lee, though not exactly worthy of a Best Actress nomination. The rest of the cast is also good: Lewis Pullman and Thomasin McKenzie being the largest supporting roles. Yet the film is consistently let down by poor writing and (at-times) mediocre directing. There are frequent voice-over narrations, never work (and that the film starts with one, almost takes the viewer instantly out of it). The film also bogs down multiple times, and the ‘dance’/prayer number usually last too long as well (the film is nearly two hours and twenty minutes). None of the songs are that memorable, even if some of the dance numbers look good. The cinematography is the best part of the movies (and seeing it in 70mm probably helped a little on that front). Even ignoring any benefits and flaws, the film never figures out what it wants to do with its titular character. She literally had a mental breakdown after losing four children before they turned one, and decided the way to cope with it was to make her religion about celibacy. The film never confronts this aspect of her character (and America’s founding by a bunch of religious nutjobs). And once the viewer realizes it is a straight-forward (but good looking) biopic that details events of a person’s life, the fundamental flaw is exposed. I also believe the film go down as superior to *Hamnet* (even if I have it ranked lower) because it does many things near perfectly, so it will have strong supporters who can overlook the larger flaws (those damn voiceovers!) in a few years. [Critics Choice – Best Actress Nominee], *Hulu*.

Tier 4: Must Watch

10. **KPop Demon Hunters:** Equal parts modern and throwback. It feels like an old-school Disney film (*Moana* came out in 2016 and that is roughly the end of the renaissance before the studio started churning out sequels) with great songs that also advance the plot. Except now the songs are KPop, and addictive as hell; ‘Soda Pop’ and ‘Golden’ are the best two from the film, and it makes sense

that ‘Golden’ is sweeping all the awards as it is the more meaningful song, but I have a soft spot for catchy nonsense. It also has two animal sidekicks in a mystical tiger and bird (who wears a hat!). It is such a throwback. There is enough character development to keep the plot moving as there are plenty of action sequences as well. The animation is rather good as well, but did not wow me like the *Spider-Verse* franchise. It feels safe to say that Sony Animation has surpassed both Disney and Pixar as America’s premier Animation Studio. [Oscars – Best Animated Feature], *Netflix*.

9. **Hamnet:** For the first hour, one actually wishes they were watching *The Testament of Ann Lee* instead, as the visuals, sets, and costumes are better in *Lee* (not to mention the birthing scenes were better). Jessie Buckley (*Wicked Little Letters*) is rather good, but the runaway train that is her Oscar campaign seems odd. The camera often does linger on her face and lets her shine. Paul Mescal (*Aftersun*) is decent as well, but again not someone who blew me away. The final third does greatly improve, but also gets into some *Hamlet* weeds, and admittedly I am not a fan of Shakespeare (and my knowledge of *Hamlet* starts and stops with *The Lion King*). The film takes some artistic license (after all the source material is a fiction novel), but given my lack of knowledge it does not bother me. The film is at times moving, and the emotional lows(?) really do hit (thanks to Buckley). Director Chloé Zhao (*Nomadland*) still doesn’t do much for me, but this is well-made, rarely bad, yet it also never reaches the tier of a must watch. [Oscars – Best Actress], *Peacock*.
8. **Weapons:** One of the most original films in a while. The originality overcomes the mediocre character development. The *Roshomon*-like plot of showing slices of different characters view on the aftermath of the event absolutely works. The film is less of a horror and more of a thriller with comedic elements (there are multiple comedic bits, and the film manages to make them work). Although the cast is very star studded, most of them don’t bring much: Josh Brolin and Julia Garner are the two worst in that regard (but that speaks more to the lack of character development). Thankfully Amy Madigan is a hoot and provides some creepiness and comedy. The themes are not what the audience expects, and detailing them would be a major spoiler. Just know that the film’s interesting premise does payoff. [Oscars – Best Supporting Actress], *HBOMax*.
7. **The Secret Agent:** Few films this year feel as lived-in as this one. The film recreates (what I assume was) 1977 Brazil. The costumes were near perfect, and so were the sets (a strong argument it should have received nominations in each of those categories). Wagner Moura (*Civil War*) is rather good in the leading role, and brings a certain charm to his character; despite not having much in the way of juicy Oscar-clip sequences. The casting of the various Brazilian actors was great as so many ‘unknowns’ give amazing performances. The camera work is often great, and the film’s climax is not what one would expect. The final epilogue is okay, but exists to show off Moura’s range. I do assume I missed a fair bit of local references. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Hulu*.
6. **Train Dreams:** An example where voiceover narration absolutely works; Will Patton’s (*Janet Planet*) narration adds to the film and helps give it a lived-in feel. In fact, the entire film feels real (even if the cinematography gives the motion a jagged look at times which I found distracting; which is sad because a lot of the shots are absolutely gorgeous; if anything that choice meant the film could never reach the next tier). Co-written and Directed by Clint Bentley (*Jockey*) the film is a pensive look at the simplicity of life and if does nail its themes, especially around love and loss. The film does start to bog down, but then in a blaze picks back up. The leads of Joel Edgerton (*Loving*) and Felicity Jones (*100 Nights of Hero*) are both rather good, but neither reaches sure-fire nomination status. The costumes are also rather nice. The film excels in its simplicity. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *Netflix*.

Tier 3: “I have a purpose. You don’t.”

5. **Marty Supreme:** Co-written and directed by Josh Safdie (*Uncut Gems*); in their first films apart it seems easy to see who is the better director and writer. I should mention I saw this in 70mm, and

received a free Marty Supreme table-tennis ball (thanks A24 Marketing Team!), though the 70mm format did not add much. The film is entirely Timothée Chalamet's as his infection used-car-salesmen energy combined with crazy drive to be the best table-tennis player, is what elevates the film to this tier. It might be the best performance of the year, and I wonder how much longer The Academy can keep avoiding giving him his rightful Oscar. The production design and costumes are rather good. The film is also more of a comedy (much like *Uncut Gems* is it a manic-paced screwball with with increasingly bizarre situations). One does wish Gwyneth Paltrow was replaced with someone else (cough Cate Blanchett cough) as although she is good, she can't exactly keep with up Chalamet and her character is meant to be one of the few who does. While Odessa A'zion (*Fresh Kills*) does a solid job of keeping up, though partially because of how her character is written. Kevin O'Leary (*Shark Tank*) is the best of the non-actors, and deserves some more praise than he's gotten. Also returning from *Uncut Gems* is composer Daniel Lopatin, whose score keeps pace with the frenzied action. The film isn't quite on par with it, but it comes close—thanks to Chalamet. [Oscars – Best Picture Nominee], *HBOMax*.

Tier 2: The Best of the Oscar Contenders

4. **Sinners:** I've long said that *The Great Gatsby* can not be considered The Great American Novel of the 1920s, because the true story of America in the 20s was the rise of the Klan and immigration restrictions; *Gatsby* portrayed the America of wealthy Coastal Elites dealing with New Money for the first time. So in someways, this film is for me (even if I wished they expanded on the Irish character a bit more). Michael B Jordan winning Best Actor is a bit of a sham, and he won by turning the campaign into a popularity contest (and dare I suggest combined with some reverse-racism?); while on the topic outside of Delroy Lindo (*Da 5 Bloods*) and Hailee Steinfeld (*The Edge of Seventeen*) no one in the cast actually stands out; the actors received a lot of nominations because the movie itself was popular. Calling the film a horror is a bit of a stretch, but it would fit under the broad-umbrella. Autumn Durald Arkapaw's (*The Last Show Girl*) cinematography is rather good; especially in the expanded IMAX ratio scenes. Continuing with production values the costumes and sets are well done, and the film features a few nice edits. *I Lied to You* as a song isn't that good, but the sequence in the film is easily one of the best of the year. As the combination of production value and themes are what makes the film excel. [Oscars – Best Original Screenplay], *HBOMax*.
3. **One Battle After Another:** I was able to see the film in 70mm IMAX, which is about as close to seeing it presented in the original VistaVision aspect ratio. The film didn't always have same impact of *Oppenheimer's* 70mm presentation. Though a few landscape shots looks great, and the shots of a car chase where amazing and felt like being on a roller coaster and I imagine the extra "height" made it look even better. History will probably be kind to the film, despite it not being Paul Thomas Anderson's masterpiece (*There Will Be Blood*), but there is a strong chance this film goes down as the definitive film of the Trump era. The film never quite gets in-your-face with the message, but at times it get a bit close. The lengthy runtime manages to work, as there is some necessary world building to drive the plot. Thankfully, the world building is often hilarious. As much like *Phantom Thread*, the film is also a comedy, though here it is a lot easier to realize that the film is also a comedy. There are countless great jokes and wackiness. Sean Penn is a surefire contender for what will be Best Supporting Actor, despite his role being more of a co-lead; this is a bit of a shame as Benicio Del Toro is rather good in a true supporting role. Leonardo DiCaprio is great as well, and probably deserving of a Best Actor nomination. Jonny Greenwood's (*Phantom Thread*) score is rather good and an underrated benefit of the film. [Oscars – Best Picture], *HBOMax*.
2. **Sentimental Value (Affeksjonsverdi):** A Joachim Trier written and directed film with Renate Reinsve in the leading role (both: *The Worst Person in the World*) is a gold mine at this point. The film is so reserved; much is left unstated but implied. The bits of narration manage to work. This

is easily one of the better films about the making of a movie (because it isn't actually about making a movie its about a family's relations). Trier's camera moves around effortlessly and often perfectly frames shots (the 'shot' of one of the father's older films is beautiful and then manages to set up essentially the rest of film; as that was the film about his mother and starred his eldest daughter and sets up the parallels to the film he is now trying to make). There is a gorgeously lit shot of a librarian entering the archives. The performances are all great and Trier is at the top of his game. [Oscars – Best International Feature], *Hulu*.

Tier 1: Best Dark Humor in Years

1. **Sorry, Baby:** Every year A24 has a lower-budget film from a debut director, that is actually their best film of the year, but come Awards Season, A24 has bigger priorities to push, so these films fly under the radar (except for Director Guild's Debut Category): *Aftersun* and *A Thousand and One*. *Sorry, Baby* is the next in line of this grand tradition. Written, directed, and starring Eva Victor she most certainly deserves both Best Original Screenplay and Best Actress. Although the screenplay can be knocked for its episodic nature (each starts with a title card reading, 'The Year with the...') and it does get a few things wrong with academia (who is able to leave a tenure-track position in one day and have a new job lined up?!). Yet, those sins are easily forgiven because the rest of the script is darkly funny, while handling its serious subject matter deftly. The drive home with another car with obnoxiously bright headlights following behind is a perfect way of showing the feelings of the character (as the lights often make it difficult to see the character's face; in a tense moment most would want the camera to linger on the face and turn into an acting showcase). The best moment, is when her adopted cat brings a still-breathing mouse into her bed (as cats are wont to do; again the comedic elements are perfect). Mildly-panicking, she grabs a paper bag (which had been holding her boots), puts the mouse in it, and uses a book to crush the mouse (she is an English professor after all), and then runs over to her awkward-yet-kind neighbor played by Lucas Hedges (*Boy Erased*). It is darkly funny, and moving, and a major announcement of things to come for Eva Victor. [Independent Spirit – Best Screenplay], *HBOMax*.